

The Vendor of Sweets



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF R. K. NARAYAN

R.K. Narayan was born in 1906 in Madras (now Chennai), a large city in southern India, during the British colonial period. His family was ethnically Tamil and Brahmin by caste (Brahmins, associated with the Hindu priesthood, have a high status in the Indian caste system). He began attending Maharaja's College at the University of Mysore in 1926. After graduating, he briefly worked as a teacher before deciding he wanted to become a writer. He made money writing articles for newspapers and magazines and, in 1930, completed his first novel, [Swami and Friends](#). However, the novel was repeatedly rejected for publication and was not released until 1935, after a mutual acquaintance showed the manuscript to British author Graham Greene (1904–1991), who championed it to his own publisher. After Narayan published his third novel, *The Dark Room* (1938), his beloved wife Rajam—whom he had married in 1933—died of typhoid, leaving him and their young daughter Hema bereft. He wrote an autobiographical novel based on these experiences called *The English Teacher* (1945). After this, Narayan's novels became less autobiographical and more experimental. In 1960, he won the Sahitya Akademi Award, an award including a large cash prize given by India's National Academy of Letters, for his novel [The Guide](#). In addition to his literary career, Narayan had a political career: 12 of the 250 members of the upper house of India's Parliament are nominated by the president for their cultural contributions, and Narayan was nominated to Parliament and served from 1986–1992. He died in 2001, at age 94, in his hometown of Chennai, India (formerly Madras).

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The Vendor of Sweets mentions that its protagonist Jagan's son Mali is in the U.S. during the assassination of John F. Kennedy, which occurred in 1963; as the events of *The Vendor of Sweets* takes place over several years, this detail suggests that the novel occurs broadly in the early-to-mid 1960s—less than two decades after India gained independence from British colonial rule in 1947. The protagonist of *The Vendor of Sweets*, Jagan, participated in the Indian independence movement in his youth and was a devoted follower of the movement's most prominent leader, Mohandas Gandhi (1869–1948). Various indigenous groups began rebelling against British presence in India early in Britain's colonization of India. The Indian National Congress, the indigenous nationalist party that eventually achieved Indian independence from Britain, was founded in 1885. Mohandas Gandhi began leading the Indian National Congress in the

1920s and through the Congress organized many nonviolent demonstrations against British colonialism and for Indian self-rule. In *The Vendor of Sweets*, protagonist Jagan recalls participating in one such demonstration, during which he removed a Union Jack and replaced it with an Indian flag—a symbolic gesture for which the colonial police beat him and put him in jail.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Like R.K. Narayan's first novel, [Swami and Friends](#) (1935) and the vast majority of his other works, *The Vendor of Sweets* takes place in the fictional southern Indian town of Malgudi and deals with social concerns such as conformity, religion, and the influence of British colonialism on Indian culture. *The Vendor of Sweets* also places itself in dialogue with ancient Indian literary traditions through allusions to Sanskrit classics such as the *Bhagavad Gita*, a central Hindu scripture that forms part of the Sanskrit epic the [Mahabharata](#) (c. 4th century B.C.E.); another central Sanskrit epic called the *Ramayana* (c. 8th century BCE); and the work of Kalidasa, a Sanskrit author and dramatist active circa the 4th and 5th centuries C.E. Though R.K. Narayan only met English author Graham Greene (1904–1991) once in person, Greene was instrumental in getting Narayan's first two novels published, and it is possible that Greene's representations of serious moral and religious crises in novels such as *The Power and the Glory* (1940), *The Heart of the Matter* (1948), and [The End of the Affair](#) (1951) may have influenced Narayan's depiction of Jagan's crisis of conscience and turn to Hindu religious retreat in *The Vendor of Sweets*. Finally, contemporary British-Indian novelist and short-story writer Jhumpa Lahiri (b. 1967) has praised the dynamism and concision of R.K. Narayan's writing, especially in his short stories; it is possible that he influenced her Pulitzer-Prize-winning short story collection *The Interpreter of Maladies* (1999).

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Vendor of Sweets
- **When Published:** 1967
- **Literary Period:** Postcolonialism
- **Genre:** Novel
- **Setting:** Malgudi, a fictional town in southern India
- **Climax:** Jagan refuses to become involved in Mali's court case, instead insisting that he will retreat from society at a religious shrine.
- **Antagonist:** Mali, American cultural hegemony
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Indian Mythology: In addition to his original fiction, R.K. Narayan published a collection of retold myths from Indian history and legend called *Gods, Demons, and Others* in 1964, as well as an abridged version of the *Ramayana*.

Educational Reform: During Narayan's six-year term in Parliament from 1986 to 1992, he focused on the need for educational reform in India, a topic he explored in fictional form in his first novel, *Swami and Friends* (1935).



PLOT SUMMARY

Jagan, who was a follower of Mohandas Gandhi during the Indian struggle for independence when Jagan was a young man, is now an older man running a sweet shop. However, Jagan himself has given up added salt and sugar. In the sweet shop, his cousin asks him why he continues to work so hard when he lives an austere life. One morning, Jagan's son Mali announces that he doesn't want to attend college anymore. Jagan feels that he should order Mali to continue in school but, afraid of upsetting his son, doesn't. That evening in the sweet shop, the cousin stops in. When Jagan explains his worries about Mali, the cousin suggests that Jagan have a frank conversation with Mali. Instead, Jagan manipulates the cousin into finding out for him why Mali wants to quit school. That night, Jagan and the cousin meet up, and the cousin shares a discovery: Mali wants to become a writer.

Later, Jagan asks Mali whether he needs a nicer table for his writing. When Mali asks how Jagan knows about his writing, Jagan dodges the question and asks what Mali is working on currently. Mali explains that he plans to write a novel for a competition, which closes at the end of September, with a 25,000-rupee prize. Mali is offended and insists he can write the novel in the few months he has left.

After September comes and goes, Jagan has no idea whether Mali finished his novel. When he expresses his concerns to his cousin, the cousin again suggests that Jagan have a conversation with Mali—and Jagan again convinces the cousin to find out the information for him instead. Later, the cousin tells Jagan that Mali wants to study creative writing in the U.S. He also reveals that Mali has stolen money from Jagan's secret home stash to pay for his passport and plane ticket. Jagan is offended by Mali's desire to learn writing in the U.S., yet he is oddly proud of the can-do spirit revealed by Mali's theft. Mali sends Jagan many letters from the U.S.—all about American culture, with no personal details. After Mali has been in the U.S. for three years, he sends word that he is returning home with a guest.

When Jagan and his cousin meet Mali at the train station, Mali introduces them to his Korean American wife, Grace. Jagan is initially uncomfortable with Grace, whom Mali never

mentioned in his letters. As Grace and Jagan get to know each other, Jagan learns that Grace, not Mali, wrote the letters that Mali sent from the U.S.

One day, Mali corners Jagan to have a business discussion with him. At the time, Mali is wearing socks with sandals—and Jagan, who thinks socks are an unhealthy Western peculiarity, becomes so distracted by Mali's socks that he fails to hear anything Mali says. Later, at the sweet shop, the cousin asks what Jagan thinks of Mali's business idea. Jagan, pumping the cousin for information, discovers that Mali plans to start a business selling **story-writing machines**. The next morning, Jagan goes to ask Mali how story-writing machines work; Mali points out that he already explained the machines to Jagan—but then shows one such machine to Jagan. Jagan mentions that the great Indian epics were composed orally, not written down at first—but Mali interrupts, saying that India needs to compete with modern countries' art and literature industries. Then he says that he needs to raise \$51,000 himself to get backing from U.S. investors.

At the sweet shop, Jagan discovers from the cousin that Mali expects Jagan to provide the investment money for his business. Jagan begins avoiding Mali and Grace at home. Meanwhile, Mali buys a used **green car** for traveling to his business ventures, much to Jagan's displeasure. One morning, Mali and Grace corner Jagan at home and ask whether he has decided about investing in Mali's business. Jagan claims not to have the money but offers Mali his sweet-shop business. Later in the day after Mali contemptuously rejects this offer, Jagan he abruptly tells the cousin that he's going to lower his prices—he has enough money, and he wants poor children to be able to buy his sweets.

After Jagan lowers his prices, he begins selling out his wares every day. Shortly thereafter, he receives a visit from the owner of the Ananda Bhavan restaurant, the owner of the canteen near the law courts, and a strange bearded man. The *Ananda Bhavan* owner and canteen owner insinuate that they want Jagan to raise his prices again so that his erratic behavior doesn't impact their businesses. Afterward, the bearded man introduces himself as the former disciple of a genius carver of Hindu gods and offers to take Jagan to his former master's shrine sometime; Jagan agrees to the trip.

The next day, Jagan and the bearded man travel to the master image-maker's remote shrine, where the bearded man reveals that his master wanted to carve the goddess Gayatri for a particular space in the shrine but died before the statue was completed. Jagan and the bearded man pull the stone the image-maker chose for Gayatri out of a pond near the shrine, and the bearded man reveals that his sole goal before he dies is to finish carving the statue of the goddess. Abruptly, he asks Jagan to purchase the shrine and help him install the statue. Jagan hesitates, though he would like a religious retreat.

When Jagan returns home, Mali corners him again and asks for a final answer about the story-writing machines. Jagan asks what will happen if he refuses to fund the business, and Mali says that Grace will have to return home, as she has nothing to do in India without the business. Shocked, Jagan says that wives must stay with their husbands. Mali contemptuously retorts that that was only true in Jagan's day. A couple days later, Grace abruptly tells Jagan that Mali wants her to leave—and that she and Mali aren't married, though Mali had promised to marry her once they came to India. Jagan, horrified that Mali and Grace are unmarried, flees to his shop. When the cousin stops in, Jagan tells him that Mali and Grace aren't married and asks what he should do. Though at first the cousin tells Jagan that Mali and Grace's marital status is their business, he eventually suggests that he can arrange a fast wedding for Mali and Grace.

Jagan, feeling unclean due to Mali and Grace being unmarried, locks the doors between his part of the house and theirs. Later, when Mali corners Jagan again about funding his business, Jagan says that Mali and Grace must marry. Mali claims that Jagan was too cheap to send Grace back to the U.S. and that Grace needs psychiatric help; then he leaves.

That evening after work, Jagan stops by a statue near his house and recalls his own arranged marriage to Mali's now-deceased mother Ambika: how their first meeting was arranged by their families, how they fell in love at first sight, and how they were barren for the first 10 years of their marriage, until Jagan's father insisted they go to the Badri Hill shrine to pray for fertility. While reminiscing, Jagan falls asleep on the statue pedestal.

When Jagan wakes up early the next morning, he decides to start a new phase of his life, going on a religious retreat until his death. He enters the house, packs a bag, and begins to walk away. As he's leaving, his cousin rushes up and tells him that Mali has been arrested under the Prohibition Act for having alcohol in his car and that they need to prepare a defense for his trial. Jagan gives the cousin money to bail Mali out of jail and offers to buy Grace a plane ticket back to the U.S. if she asks. But he refuses to involve himself in the trial, insisting that he will go on a religious retreat to the bearded man's shrine.

student, while Jagan is focused on his faith and his beliefs about healthy eating (he has even written a book on the subject). Jagan and Mali have struggled to connect since Ambika's death, mostly because Jagan fears offending Mali or making their relationship worse. Most of what Jagan knows about Mali he learns from the cousin, who acts as a go-between for father and son. Jagan is conflicted about how to react when Mali drops out of college to write, steals money to go to the U.S., and returns several years later to start a business manufacturing **story-writing machines**. Jagan believes that Mali has been inappropriately influenced by American and British cultural ideals, and it disturbs him that Mali seems not to value Indian culture and the independent Indian nation that Jagan fought so hard for. But rather than talk to Mali directly—or refuse outright to invest in Mali's business venture—Jagan continues to communicate through the cousin and tries to immerse himself more deeply in his faith. Ultimately, just as Mali is arrested for alcohol possession, Jagan decides to go on a religious retreat. He leaves money for Mali's bail but otherwise he fully disconnects from his family.

Mali – Mali, son of Jagan and Ambika, is a sullen, callous, commercially-minded young man living in southern India in the 1960s. Ambika dies when Mali is a child, and Jagan's resulting breakdown leads to estrangement between Jagan and Mali. Though secretive and dismissive with Jagan, Mali sometimes confides in Jagan's cousin, whom he calls "uncle." After 20-year-old Mali announces that he plans to quit college, Jagan learns from his cousin that Mali wants to be a writer—specifically, that he wants to study creative writing in the U.S. After more than three years in the U.S., Mali returns with an American girlfriend named Grace—whom he falsely tells Jagan is his wife—and an ambition: to Westernize and "modernize" India, which he has come to hold in contempt. He plans to do this through American **story-writing machines**, which mechanize much of the individual creative work of composing novels. Mali, planning to found a story-machine factory, sees Jagan and Grace as mere means to that end. He relentlessly pursues Jagan for start-up money to fund his business, despite Jagan's obvious unwillingness; moreover, when Grace runs out of savings and can't work at Mali's not-yet-funded business, he tries to send her back to the U.S. and accuses her of mental instability when she doesn't go. As the novel ends, Mali has just been arrested after police found alcohol inside his **green car** (alcohol was illegal in many regions of India at the time of the novel's publication). This situation emphasizes the negative consequences of Mali's Westernization and contempt for Indian culture and law.

Grace – Grace is the daughter of a Korean woman and an American G.I., who brought Grace and her mother to New Jersey and abandoned them there. While at college in Michigan, Grace meets Mali and becomes romantically involved with him. She accompanies him back to India to help



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Jagan – The novel's protagonist, Jagan, is a timid, devout Hindu man in his late 50s who owns a sweet shop in southern India in the 1960s. As a young man, Jagan entered into an arranged marriage with Ambika, and they eventually had a son, Mali. Jagan was also heavily involved with India's independence movement in his youth. In the present, Ambika has been deceased for about 10 years and Mali is a 20-year-old college

him start a **story-writing machine** factory and lives with him and his father Jagan under the pretense that she and Mali are married. Unlike Mali, who is contemptuous of his father and his native country, Grace embraces Indian and Hindu culture and tries hard to become part of the family. Perhaps due to her biological father's abandonment, she seems particularly happy to be Jagan's "daughter-in-law," making repeated overtures of friendship toward him. Though Jagan sometimes finds her naïve enthusiasm for India and Hinduism off-putting, he believes she is a "good girl." When Jagan won't provide the start-up money for Mali's story-writing-machine factory and Grace's savings run out, Mali and Grace's relationship breaks down—suggesting that while Grace wanted to become part of Mali's family, Mali was interested in Grace primarily as a future employee and a source of cash. When Jagan tries to convince Mali to marry Grace—as Grace alleges he promised he would—Mali claims that she is mentally unstable. Yet despite her past wounds and obvious unhappiness, Grace eventually moves out of Mali's family home and gets a job at a hostel, implying that she is more resilient than Mali realizes.

The Cousin – The cousin is a friendly busybody who claims to be related to nearly everyone in the southern Indian town of Malgudi, including Jagan. Each day around 4:30 p.m., he stops into Jagan's sweet shop, samples the wares, and gives Jagan advice about ingredients and prices. Whenever Jagan is too afraid of offending his son Mali to ask Mali something directly, he asks the cousin—whom Mali calls "uncle"—to find out the relevant information for him. Though the cousin repeatedly advises Jagan to speak with Mali directly, he inevitably gives in to Jagan's requests to play go-between because he likes being included in family matters. Unlike Jagan, who is suspicious of Mali's **story-writing machine** business idea and horrified by Mali's premarital relationship with Grace, the cousin has a more laissez-faire attitude, believing that commerce is generally good and that each generation has its own behavioral mores. As the novel ends, the cousin has just rushed to tell Jagan that Mali has been arrested for alcohol possession and is trying to convince Jagan to get involved with the legal case. Though Jagan refuses to get involved, insisting on retiring to a religious shrine instead, he gives the cousin money for Mali's bail and leaves the cousin in charge of his sweet shop until such time as Mali agrees to take it over.

The Bearded Man – The bearded man, bald but with a full white beard, is the 69-year-old former disciple of a genius carver of religious statues, whom he claims adopted him at age 5 after he was orphaned. Though he makes his living selling hair dye, he longs to finish his dead master's final project: a statue of the goddess Gayatri to be installed in a particular niche in his dead master's workplace and shrine. After he has completed this project, he feels that he can die. He approaches Jagan, brings him to the shrine, and tries to convince him to buy the property and fund the statue-carving. As the novel ends, Jagan

has decided to move to the shrine and pursue the bearded man's plan.

Ambika – Ambika, wife to Jagan and mother to Mali, died of a brain tumor about 10 years before the main events of *The Vendor of Sweets*. Jagan fell in love with her at first sight after his family arranged for him to meet her as a prospective bride. After their large, traditional Hindu wedding, Jagan was so preoccupied by spending time with her and having sex with her that he repeatedly failed his college exams. His infatuation annoyed her somewhat, as it distracted her from her household tasks and made her look bad in front of his family, but they maintained a loving relationship. For many years, they had no children—to Ambika's shame—until Jagan's father insisted that Jagan and Ambika go on a fertility retreat, after which Jagan and Ambika had Mali. Ambika died when Mali was about 10 years old.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Nataraj – Nataraj is the proprietor of Truth Printing, the print shop that makes Mali's business prospectus and that Jagan believes will eventually print his monograph on natural diets and health.

Ananda Bhavan owner – The owner of *Ananda Bhavan*, a restaurant in Malgudi, visits Jagan in an attempt to bully him into raising his prices again after he substantially lowers them.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



COMMUNICATION VS. FEAR

In *The Vendor of Sweets*, fear destroys people's ability to communicate. Its protagonist Jagan consistently fails to communicate openly and honestly because he fears anger and rejection. For instance, early in the novel, Jagan's 20-year-old son Mali announces that he no longer wants to go to the Indian college he has been attending. Jagan, baffled, is speculating Mali's possible motives with his cousin when the cousin suggests that Jagan just talk to Mali about Mali's motives directly. Instead of taking this advice, Jagan uses flattery to convince the cousin to find out Mali's motives for Jagan. Jagan continues to refuse to confront Mali directly about his choices, and he continues to ignore his cousin's advice and insight in favor of direct communication. Jagan's failures to communicate out of fear extend so far that eventually, he disappears on a religious retreat rather than try to find out why Mali has been arrested for alcohol possession.

Nor is Mali the only person with whom Jagan fails to communicate out of fear. Jagan wants to establish a loving and familial relationship with Grace, the young woman whom Mali brought home from America. When Jagan discovers that Grace and Mali are not married, as Mali initially claimed, and that Mali is trying to send Grace back to America, Jagan attempts to have an honest, affectionate conversation with Grace—yet as soon as Grace becomes emotional, Jagan gets frightened and decides to flee rather than get to the bottom of Grace and Mali's conflict. As the novel ends, Jagan concedes that Grace is a "good girl" whom he and his family have a duty to treat right—yet he says this not to Grace herself but once again to his cousin, whom he relies on as his intermediary. Through Jagan's repeated unwillingness to communicate directly with Mali and Grace, the novel illustrates how a fear of direct communication, and a subsequent unwillingness to communicate directly, leads a person to sabotage their relationships.



GENERATIONAL DIFFERENCE

The Vendor of Sweets represents generational difference as an unavoidable result of historical change. The novel's protagonist, Jagan, is an Indian

man who participated in the nonviolent political campaign led by Mohandas Gandhi (1869–1948) to end British colonial rule in India. Jagan's participation in this campaign shaped his life. Colonial police beat and jailed him for replacing a Union Jack with the Indian flag; while in jail, he was assigned to kitchen detail, and so after his release and Indian independence, he opened a sweets shop using what he had learned during his incarceration. In the present, then, he defines himself as proudly Indian and values many of the qualities and activities he learned from Gandhi. In contrast with Jagan, Jagan's son Mali does not share Jagan's values of social service, Indian national pride, or adequate, honest work in a respectable trade. The novel implies that Mali's differences are in large part due to his age: he is too young to remember colonial India or to have internalized the values of the Indian independence struggle. Instead of being shaped by national pride, then, Mali is shaped by post-World War II global capitalism: he dreams of founding a factory in India, with backing from U.S. investors, that makes **story-writing machines** to mechanize individual creativity and increase India's cultural output in quantitative terms with less overall work. Because the novel implies that Jagan and his son Mali are each shaped by their different historical moments, it also implies that generational difference—as well as the generational conflict it inspires—is due to global historical changes beyond any person's or family's control.



COMMERCE, TASTE, AND THE GOOD LIFE

In *The Vendor of Sweets*, what people can buy affects what they desire—blinding them to the nature of

the good life, which the novel defines as satisfaction and happiness with one's lot in life. This, the novel suggests, often requires far fewer material goods than people realize. Jagan, the novel's protagonist, runs a sweet shop in the fictional Indian town of Malgudi. Notably, Jagan himself does not sample his wares; he has given up added sugars in an attempt to live in a happier and holier way, suggesting that his commercial wares are unnecessary to—and are perhaps opposed to—a good life. When Jagan lowers the prices of his sweets so that poor children can afford them, moreover, he creates unhappiness: more people want the cheaper sweets, the shop sells out faster, and many angry people go away empty-handed. Jagan's lack of interest in his own commercial wares, and the counterintuitive unhappiness that the cheaper sweets cause, both suggest that sweets and other luxury items are at least unnecessary for a good life, if not outright opposed to the good life. In a similar vein, Jagan's son Mali wants to be a writer—until he goes to America and discovers the existence of **story-writing machines**, which mechanize creative work. Mali's vague artistic aspirations soon give way to commercial ones: he decides that he wants to start a factory for story-writing machines in India, make lots of money, and increase the number of novels that India produces (while presumably lowering the quality of those novels). In the pursuit of this factory, Mali becomes more and more unhappy and is eventually arrested for alcohol possession while going to meet with foreign investors. By highlighting the unhappiness that Jagan's lowered prices and Mali's story-writing machines cause, the novel suggests that more commerce, more goods, and more money don't necessarily translate to better lives, either for consumers or for producers.



RELIGION

In *The Vendor of Sweets*, religion represents a detached, generous outlook on reality that, the novel suggests, is very difficult to sustain—and that can easily be perverted into a cowardly avoidance of worldly problems. The novel's protagonist, Jagan, is a semi-devout practitioner of Hinduism: he regularly reads the *Bhagavad Gita*, a central scripture in Hinduism, and prays to the gods for guidance in his family home's *puja* room. When he practices his religion sincerely, Jagan's beliefs allow him to detach himself from money concerns and overinvestment in worldly outcomes. Yet Jagan is inconsistent in his religious practice. For example, he reads the *Gita* at the sweet shop he owns and allows himself to be distracted from the scripture any time the cooks he employs cease frying sweets. And while he tries to use his piety to try to stave off anxiety—particularly anxiety about his feckless son Mali—he usually fails. Moreover, when the novel ends, Jagan has finally forsworn his worldly business and worldly cares and plans to go on a permanent religious retreat—yet the novel suggests that Jagan takes this retreat to avoid the problem of Mali and Mali's girlfriend Grace, who are

refusing to get married, rather than to express genuine religious devotion. Thus, the novel represents Jagan's Hinduism as a noble belief system that encourages emotional detachment and generosity—that the average person will find difficult to follow and that Jagan specifically uses as an excuse to avoid his interpersonal problems. This nuanced take suggests that religious ideals are often admirable and worth striving for, though many followers may very well struggle to follow a faith's precepts in full.



INDIA VS. THE U.K. AND THE U.S.

The Vendor of Sweets represents India as a country whose national character is corrupted first by British colonialism and then by U.S.-dominated global capitalism. The novel takes place after British colonial rule in India has ended; its protagonist, Jagan, participated in the nonviolent independence movement led by Mohandas Gandhi (1869–1948). Yet the novel represents the Indian patriot Jagan as something of an outlier in a community largely comfortable with British cultural influences. For example, Jagan's family insists he wear a British-style tweed suit when he gets married rather than a *dhoti* and *jibba* as he would prefer, and a statue of a (fictional) British colonizer Sir Frederick Lawley continues to stand in the square near Jagan's house long after independence. Meanwhile, in the aftermath of Indian independence, the U.S. becomes another globally hegemonic cultural force interfering with India's national character. While the older generation, represented by Jagan and his cousin, imagine the U.S. as a den of sin and injustice and so define India as good largely in contrast with wicked America, the younger generation, represented by Jagan's son Mali, treats the U.S. and all it stands for as the future. As Mali sees it, the U.S. is a fount of progress and bounty, and so he insists on imitating what he perceives to be American cultural norms. In both cases, the novel represents India as struggling to define itself in the face of the UK and the U.S.'s inescapable, hegemonic cultural influences.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



STORY-WRITING MACHINES

In *The Vendor of Sweets*, the story-writing machines represent how generational differences impede communication between Jagan, who owns a sweet-shop in southern India in the 1960s, and his son Mali. When Jagan learns that Mali is quitting college to become a writer, he comforts himself with the idea that Mali's literary output will constitute a "service" to the public. He understands Mali's

literary "service" by paralleling it with his own service as a young man to the Indian independence movement—a parallel that suggests Jagan believes that Mali's work will serve Indian literary culture. Yet after Mali goes to study creative writing in the U.S., he returns to India with a dream not of contributing to Indian literature himself but of manufacturing American "story-writing machines" in India. These machines will standardize and streamline the process of novel-writing, thus increasing India's overall commercial fiction output and enlarging its publishing industry.

When Mali first tries to convince Jagan to fund this business venture, Jagan is so distracted by the fact that Mali is wearing socks—which Jagan considers unhealthy, Western clothing items—that Jagan fails to pay any attention to what Mali is saying. Jagan only learns the details of the story-writing-machine business when his cousin, a man of his own generation, talks to Mali about it and then explains it to Jagan. Later, when Jagan points out in Mali's hearing that foundational Indian epics were composed and transmitted orally for many generations, Mali interrupts Jagan—another instance of their communication breaking down—to argue that India needs to "compete" with "advanced cultures" in its literary output and so needs the story-writing machines. From there, the story-writing machines lead to further breakdowns in communication between father and son, with Mali demanding money from Jagan and Jagan avoiding Mali or refusing to respond to his questions and demands. Thus, the story-writing machine represents how people of Mali's generation, influenced by hegemonically Western global capitalism, and people of Jagan's generation, who came of age during the patriotic Indian independence movement, have difficulty communicating with one another due to their different generations' cultural suppositions.



GREEN CAR

In *The Vendor of Sweets*, Mali's green car symbolizes how material goods, though apparently desirable, often fail to contribute to a good life. Before Mali leaves India for America to study creative writing, he gets around his hometown of Malgudi by walking or bicycling—and his bicycle is perfectly adequate to his transportation needs. After Mali returns to India with a plan to start a **story-writing machine** factory, he buys a used green car to facilitate his business travel—yet as Mali has not yet started his business, the car seems to be more a status symbol and a luxury item than a necessity. Later, Mali's father Jagan encounters Mali and his girlfriend Grace driving around in the car together after Mali and Grace's relationship has begun to crumble; the oddity of Mali and Grace joyriding together as their relationship fails shows that the green car, though a status symbol, cannot solve Mali's personal or business problems. Finally, a police officer stops and searches Mali's car, finds some alcohol in it, and

arrests Mali (in the Indian region of Tamil Nadu, where the novel is implied to take place, alcohol was illegal until 1971). That Mali's status symbol lead to his risky behavior—driving with alcohol—and his arrest shows how apparently desirable commercial goods can actually make people's lives worse.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Indian Thought Publications edition of *The Vendor of Sweets* published in 2007.

Chapter 1 Quotes

“Conquer taste, and you will have conquered the self,” said Jagan to his listener, who asked, “Why conquer the self?” Jagan said, “I do not know, but all our sages advise us so.”

Related Characters: Jagan, The Cousin (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 7

Explanation and Analysis

This paragraph, which opens *The Vendor of Sweets*, finds Jagan—the eponymous vendor of sweets—talking to a “listener,” his cousin, about conquering both “taste” and “the self.” The paragraph introduces two questions that will animate the rest of the novel: What is the relationship of “taste” and commerce to a good life? And what role should religion play in a good life?

First, Jagan is advising the cousin to “conquer taste,” a phrase that implies overcoming one's materialistic desires for tempting food in particular and for tempting commercial goods more generally. Yet Jagan himself sells tempting food as a commercial good to others. This ironically suggests that even if Jagan has begun conquering *himself*, he hasn't fully extricated himself from the web of commercial relationships that keep people controlled by their own “tastes” and passing desires. The ironic contrast between Jagan's advice to the cousin and his actual commercial behavior emphasizes that, throughout the rest of the novel, Jagan will need to decide whether his current business accords with his own deeply held beliefs.

Second, Jagan refers to “our sages” when justifying his claims about conquering taste and the self. The word “sage” means a wise man, but it can have religious connotations, and later the novel will reveal that Jagan is a devout Hindu. Notably, Jagan himself admits that he doesn't know *why* one

should conquer taste or the self but refers to implicitly religious teaching to justify his belief that one should. Jagan's inability to justify the religious teachings he accepts from others suggests that he needs to figure out for himself what role his religion is going to play in determining his behavior.

As long as the frying and sizzling noise in the kitchen continued and the trays passed, Jagan noticed nothing, his gaze unflinchingly fixed on the Sanskrit lines in a red-bound copy of the *Bhagavad Gita*, but if there was the slightest pause in the sizzling, he cried out, without lifting his eyes from the sacred text, “What is happening?”

Related Characters: Jagan (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 12

Explanation and Analysis

Here the narrator describes Jagan's habitual behavior while his sweet shop is open for business, behavior that reveals the tension between Jagan's devout Hinduism and his commercial activities. The *Bhagavad Gita* is a very important Hindu scripture—a 700-verse section of the longer Hindu scripture and Sanskrit epic the *Mahabharata*—that represents a dialogue between the god Vishnu incarnated as his avatar Krishna and the prince Arjuna.

As an important and complex piece of religious writing, the *Gita* deserves respectful attention from the devout Hindu Jagan. Yet Jagan is only able to ignore the commercial activities in his shop—the “frying and sizzling noise” indicating that his employees are making sweets, for example—so long as they seem to be proceeding well. If “the slightest pause” occurs in the commercial activity around him, he stops paying full attention to the *Gita*. Jagan's inability to pay full attention to the *Gita* when his business is not running perfectly smoothly represents in miniature how Jagan's commercial activities distract him and lead him astray from his genuine religious devotion.

Chapter 2 Quotes

Everything in this house had the sanctity of usage, which was the reason why no improvement was possible.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 19

Explanation and Analysis

This passage, describing the family home that Jagan has inherited from his own parents, is explaining why Jagan has not renovated the property despite, for example, its having no indoor toilet. The house has “the sanctity of usage”; as “sanctity” means “holiness,” this phrase suggests that because the house has sheltered and been used by multiple generations of Jagan’s family, the building and its grounds have acquired a quasi-religious aura. It would thus be an insult to previous generations of the family to attempt to “improve[]” the house Jagan’s father has left to him. This attitude shows Jagan’s respect for previous generations of his family and the way they did things.

Yet later in the novel, Jagan will end up renovating the house. Jagan’s discontented son Mali goes to study creative writing in the U.S. for several years, and when he sends Jagan a telegram announcing that he is coming back with another person, Jagan spends a frantic few weeks before Mali’s actual arrival installing an indoor toilet near Mali’s room, repainting the walls, and buying new furniture. Jagan renovates the house against his own wishes because he fears the newly Americanized Mali’s reaction if the house remains as it is. This unwilling renovation shows the generational conflict between the spiritual, traditional Jagan and the secular, Westernized Mali; it also lightly implies that too much contact with U.S. culture may cause unnecessary changes in Indian culture.

☛ Jagan found his son’s attraction to aspirin ominous. He merely replied, “I’ll get you better things to eat than this pill. Forget it, you understand?”

Related Characters: Jagan (speaker), Mali, Ambika

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 22

Explanation and Analysis

In a flashback, Jagan has attempted to convince his wife Ambika, who has a headache, to eat a natural medicine remedy (margosa flowers) rather than take some aspirin. When Jagan loses the argument with Ambika and goes to

ask his young son Mali where the aspirin is, Mali explains that Ambika keeps it in the highest part of a cupboard where she thinks Mali can’t reach because his “attraction” to it worries her. Jagan, who also finds Mali’s “attraction to aspirin ominous,” promises him “better things to eat than this pill.”

This scene foreshadows Mali’s excessive devotion to modern conveniences and American-dominated global capitalism in his adulthood. Whereas aspirin is safe when taken in the appropriate dose, it can be lethal if a person takes too much—which implicitly why Ambika keeps the aspirin on a high shelf that Mali can’t reach. In the same way, the novel suggests, judiciously accepting certain modern ideas, conveniences, and innovations is fine and healthy. But wanting progress for the sake of progress leads to enthusiasm for poisonous commercial products like Mali’s beloved story-writing machines, which automate what the novel suggests ought to be an individual creative process and so make mockery of artistic work.

Jagan’s nervous attempt here to influence Mali’s tastes and desires by offering him “better things to eat” seems likely to fail. As such, it foreshadows his failed attempts to dissuade Mali from pursuing the story-writing machine business by offering him the sweet shop, a humbler and less innovative but also less destructive business.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☛ “Writer” meant in Jagan’s dictionary only one thing—a “clerk”—an Anglo-Indian, colonial term since the days when Macaulay had devised a system of education to provide a constant supply of clerical staff for the East India Company. Jagan felt ghast. Here he was trying to shape the boy into an aristocrat with a bicycle, college life, striped shirts, and everything, and he wanted to be a “writer”! Strange!

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali, The Cousin

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 28–29

Explanation and Analysis

The cousin has just informed Jagan that Mali wants to be a writer. Jagan misinterprets the word “writer” due its preexisting use as “an Anglo-Indian, colonial term” to mean “clerk” and is horrified by Mali’s perversely lowly ambition. Jagan’s mistake emphasizes that differences between his and Mali’s generational contexts hinders them from

understanding one another.

The East India Company (1600–1847) was an English company that began establishing factories and settlements in India in the early 1600s, paving the way for the UK’s later official political takeover of India that resulted in foreign British rule in colonial India from 1858 to 1947. Thomas Babington Macaulay (1800–1859) was an English politician who led efforts to make English the official language of Indian high schools, among other reforms to Westernize and Anglicize the Indian education system.

Jagan, who participated in the anti-English, anti-colonial Indian independence movement that culminated in India’s freedom from British colonial rule in 1947, is naturally horrified by the idea that Mali would want to become a “clerk,” a job that the East India Company and British educational reforms had forced upon colonized Indian people in pre-independence years. Yet Mali—who, the novel suggests, would have been quite a young child when India became independent—isn’t aware that “writer” can mean “clerk.” In fact, he wants to be a novelist. Thus this scene suggests that the importance of British colonial rule and the Indian independence movement to Jagan causes him to misunderstand his son, who is of a different generation and for whom these political concerns are less present.

Even with the passage of time, Jagan never got over the memory of that moment. The coarse, raw pain he had felt at the sight of Mali on that fateful day remained petrified in some vital centre of his being. From that day, the barrier had come into being. The boy had ceased to speak to him normally.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali, Ambika

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 38

Explanation and Analysis

The narrator has just related Jagan’s perspective on an important memory from 10 years prior to the main story events: just after a doctor informed Jagan that his wife Ambika was going to die of brain cancer very shortly, Mali asked Jagan what the doctor had said. Jagan broke down emotionally, after which he perceived Mali giving him a disturbed, confused look.

It is unclear whether Jagan is an entirely reliable narrator in his scene. He claims that Mali “ceased to speak to him normally” after witnessing his breakdown and that an interpersonal “barrier” fell between them as a result. Yet his

interpretation seems based mainly on Mali giving him a disturbed, confused look during his emotional breakdown—which seems like a reasonable reaction on 10-year-old Mali’s part, given that he had asked Jagan a question about his mother’s health and that Jagan had begun to wail in grief rather than answering.

Moreover, Jagan himself admits that he carries in the “centre of his being” a “coarse, raw pain” at seeing Mali after learning that Mali’s mother was going to die. The sight of Mali may continue to remind Jagan of his helplessness to save his wife or protect his son from grief. As such, though it is entirely possible that Mali did recoil emotionally from Jagan’s breakdown, it seems possible that Jagan contributed to the “barrier” between himself and his son by withdrawing from Mali out of grief or fear of rejection—a withdrawal he doesn’t acknowledge or even seem to recognize.

Chapter 4 Quotes

“I hate to upset him, that’s all. I have never upset him in all my life.”

“That means you have carried things to the point where you cannot speak to him at all.”

Related Characters: Jagan, The Cousin (speaker), Mali, Ambika

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 45

Explanation and Analysis

Jagan wants his cousin to find out what Mali is doing with his time now that he has quit college—without letting Mali know that Jagan has asked the cousin to do so. When the cousin asks what Jagan is scared of, Jagan claims that he doesn’t want to “upset” Mali and claims that he has “never upset [Mali].”

It’s false that Jagan has never upset Mali. Earlier in the novel, Jagan clearly recounts having upset a much younger Mali by breaking down emotionally when Mali asked Jagan what the doctor had said about Ambika in her final hours. Thus, it seems that Jagan found his emotional breakdown in front of Mali and Mali’s confused, distressed reaction so traumatic that he has scrupulously avoided upsetting Mali since then—and sometimes represses his memories of the main occasion on which he upset Mali in childhood.

Due to Jagan’s fear of upsetting Mali, the cousin argues,

Jagan “cannot speak to [Mali] at all.” This argument suggests that conflict is an unavoidable part of long-term communication between two people, so that by avoiding upsetting Mali, Jagan ends up avoiding any meaningful communication with him. The novel bears out the cousin’s argument: again and again, Jagan avoids having frank and open discussions with his son that might help them better understand each other. Thus, Jagan’s fear of Mali’s negative emotional reactions has thoroughly undermined their communication.

“Did Valmiki go to America or Germany in order to write his *Ramayana*?” asked Jagan with pugnacity. “Strange notions these boys get nowadays!”

Related Characters: Jagan (speaker), Mali, The Cousin

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 47

Explanation and Analysis

The cousin has just informed Jagan that Mali wants to go to the U.S. to study creative writing. Jagan, rather offended by this idea, rhetorically asks whether Valmiki traveled to the U.S. or Germany to write the *Ramayana*. The *Ramayana*, a Sanskrit epic that constitutes one of the most important Hindu scriptures, was composed over many centuries, from the 8th century B.C.E. to the 3rd century C.E., but the *Ramayana* itself names Valmiki as its original author. Jagan’s rhetorical question is thus intended to point out that India’s foundational writers did not need to study Western models in the U.S. or Germany to write globally important literary classics.

Jagan’s scorn for the “notions” of Indian “boys” “nowadays”—specifically, the notion of studying writing in the U.S.—reveals a generational difference in how Jagan and Mali think about the West. Jagan participated in the Indian independence movement to end British colonial rule of India, due to which India gained independence in 1947. Having been shaped by the cultural context of Indian patriotic struggle against a major Western power, Jagan is highly patriotic and suspicious of Western powers in general, the U.S. as well as the U.K.

By contrast, Mali would have been a young child when India became independent. As he lacks Jagan’s first-hand experience with colonialism, he has comparatively pro-Western sentiments, thinking of countries like the U.S. as

wealthy vanguards of economic and cultural progress. This generational difference in attitude fuels much conflict between Jagan and Mali throughout the novel.

“They eat only beef and pork in that country. I used to know a man from America, and he told me . . .”

“They also take a lot of intoxicating drinks, never water or milk,” said the cousin, contributing his own bit of information.

Related Characters: Jagan, The Cousin (speaker), Mali

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 48

Explanation and Analysis

Jagan and his cousin are discussing with some alarm why Mali would possibly want to go to America. This discussion reveals that while Jagan and his generation may have legitimate anti-colonial reasons for disliking Western powers, their specific judgments of the U.S. are based on a mixture of facts and false stereotypes. By revealing that Jagan and the cousin’s beliefs about America are partly true and partly absurd, the novel cautions readers against automatically assuming the attitudes of Jagan’s generation are more accurate than those of his son Mali’s.

Jagan and the cousin take genuine differences between American and Indian cultures—and exaggerate them until they become untrue. For example, it is true that people in the U.S. eat far more meat per capita than people in India, which has a robust history of religious vegetarianism, yet it is obviously false and exaggerated to say that Americans eat “only beef and pork.” Similarly, India has a more recent history of outlawing alcohol than the U.S. does:

Prohibition—the outlawing of alcohol—was repealed in the U.S. in 1933, whereas India’s 1947 constitution endorsed prohibition and several Indian states still have prohibition laws on the books. Yet, again, it is obviously untrue to claim that Americans “never [drink] water or milk.”

Thus, while the novel may sympathize with Jagan’s suspicion of Western powers and represent Mali’s Americanization in a negative light, it also pokes some fun at exaggerated or misinformed anti-American sentiment.

Chapter 5 Quotes

“Gradually his reading of the *Bhagavad Gita* was replaced by the blue airmail letters.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali, Grace

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 56

Explanation and Analysis

After Mali travels to the U.S., he begins sending Jagan airmail letters describing the U.S. and American culture. Jagan reads and rereads these letters so obsessively that they eventually supplant his daily reading of the *Bhagavad Gita*, an important Hindu scripture. This supplanting shines light on two facets of Jagan's character.

First, Jagan is genuinely devoted to Mali despite his frequent avoidance of and difficulties communicating with his son. He is so touched by Mali voluntarily communicating with him that he treats Mali's letters almost as if they were sacred texts. Sadly, Jagan will later learn that Mali's girlfriend Grace, not Mali himself, composed the bulk of these letters—a fact suggesting that Jagan's quiet, avoidant adoration of Mali won't be enough to establish real communication between them.

Second, although Jagan is a devout Hindu, familial or commercial concerns often distract him from his religious practice. Readers have already witnessed how any hitch in the smooth operation of his sweet shop can distract him from his religious reading. Now, in this quotation, the novel portrays his rereading his son's letters instead of continuing his intent study of a Hindu religious text as yet another form of him getting distracted. These distractions show the difficulty of living a committed religious life in the secular world, even for a devout man like Jagan.

☞ The only letter Jagan rigorously suppressed was the one in which Mali had written, after three years' experience of America, "I've taken to eating beef; and I don't think I'm any the worse for it. Steak is something quite tasty and juicy. Now I want to suggest why not you people start eating beef? It'll solve the problem of useless cattle in our country and we won't have to beg food from America. I sometimes feel ashamed when India asks for American aid. Instead of that, why not slaughter useless cows which wander in the streets and block traffic?"

Related Characters: Mali (speaker), Jagan

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 57–58

Explanation and Analysis

This is part of a letter from Mali to Jagan, in which Mali suggests India slaughter cows for food. Cows are sacred in Hinduism, and so killing and eating a cow is consequently a grave religious offense. When Mali writes to his devoutly Hindu father that he has begun eating beef and that Indian people should kill their cows rather than ask for food aid, he reveals both his callous disregard for his father's feelings and his Western secularization in contrast with Jagan's Hinduism and Indian patriotism.

Mali chooses to tell Jagan that he has begun eating beef in an unnecessarily callous way. It is offensive to tell someone who holds cows sacred that their dead flesh is "something quite tasty and juicy"—a perception that Mali does not need to share in order to express religious differences with his father. Similarly, it is offensive to describe sacred cows as "useless cattle" to a Hindu person even if one does not personally believe that cows are sacred. Mali does not need to employ inflammatory descriptions and derogatory language to tell his father that they hold different beliefs. But he does it anyway, showing his callousness and immaturity and emphasizing that the communication problems in Jagan and Mali's relationship are hardly all Jagan's fault.

In addition to illustrating Mali's callousness, the letter implies that Mali wants to reform Indian society along secular and Western lines: he thinks that animals sacred to large swathes of the Indian population are less important than not "block[ing] traffic," thereby privileging efficient traffic flow over Indian religion and culture. Mali's desire to Westernize India foreshadows further conflict with Jagan, a former activist for Indian independence from the U.K. who has strong patriotic sentiments and is suspicious of Western powers on principle.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ "You are not one who knows how to make money. If you were unscrupulous, you could have built many mansions, who knows?"

"And what would one do with many mansions?"

Related Characters: Jagan, The Cousin (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 72

Explanation and Analysis

The cousin and Jagan are bantering in Jagan's sweet shop

about the “unscrupulous”—that is, cutthroat and unethical—practices of some other food merchants in town. When Jagan boasts that he hasn’t raised his own prices, the cousin jokingly tells him that he doesn’t know “how to make money” and has missed the opportunity for “many mansions.” In response, Jagan asks rhetorically “what one would do with many mansions?”

Jagan’s rhetorical question makes an important point about wealth: though in theory one can go on accumulating money endlessly, one only needs—and can only use—a limited number of things. Therefore, the capitalist logic of endless accumulation and economic growth doesn’t necessarily make sense: it’s reasonable for person like Jagan to stop working once he has enough, at least in theory.

Yet, while it’s obvious to Jagan that he has no use for “many mansions,” it isn’t always clear from Jagan’s actions how many material possessions are necessary for a good life. For example, though Jagan lives very simply, he continues accumulating wealth as a successful small business owner. Why? This question lies at the root of Jagan’s internal conflict around his business for much of the novel.

☛ Jagan asked, “Do you want to use this for writing stories?” “Yes, I am also going to manufacture and sell it in this country. An American company is offering to collaborate. In course of time, every home in the country will possess one and we will produce more stories than any other nation in the world. Right now we are a little backward. Except *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata*, those old stories, there is no modern writing, whereas in America alone every publishing season ten thousand books are published.”

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 80

Explanation and Analysis

Mali again explain to Jagan his plan to start a business manufacturing story-writing machines in India. This time, Jagan is actually paying attention. When Jagan asks whether Mali “want[s] to use this for writing stories?”, the startled question seemed disappointed. Implicitly, Jagan seems to believe that writing a story using a machine is the opposite of creative behavior, indicating that he possesses

traditional ideas about individual artistic genius.

Mali’s response is informative for two reasons. First, he talks far more about his desire to manufacture and sell the machines than he does about any desire he might have to compose stories with them. Mali’s focus on the business side of things implies that he may always have looked at writing primarily as a means of making money rather than as a way to express himself artistically.

Second, he focuses on the *number* of stories the machines will enable India to produce and conflates “modern writing” with producing “ten thousand books a year”—a focus that completely ignores questions of literary quality. He calls foundational pieces of ancient Indian literature, the Sanskrit epics *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata*, “old stories”—word choice that suggests he believes that literary masterpieces depreciate with age. Mali’s relentless focus on quantity and novelty in literature, as opposed to quality and staying power, render the story-writing machines symbolic of his Westernized, highly capitalist views on art—in stark contrast with Jagan’s reverence for the great Indian epic. This contrast renders the story-writing machines a symbol of the breakdown in communication between Jagan and Mali—and between Jagan’s older, patriotic generation and Mali’s younger, Westernized, capitalist one.

☛ Prayer was a sound way of isolating oneself—but sooner or later it ended: one could not go on praying eternally, though one ought to.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali, Grace

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 85

Explanation and Analysis

Mali has asked Jagan to fund his story-writing-machine business. Jagan, intensely conflict-avoidant, doesn’t want to fund the business but also doesn’t want to tell Mali no. One morning, while Jagan is praying, Mali enters the room and begins to approach the topic of the story-writing machines indirectly—only for his more sensitive girlfriend Grace to summon Mali away so that he doesn’t disturb Jagan’s prayers.

In response, Jagan thinks that prayer is “a sound way of isolating oneself,” though it is not a permanent solution because “one could not go on praying eternally.” This

thought reveals that while Jagan is a genuinely devout Hindu, he also uses religion instrumentally to avoid his worldly and familial problems—in this case, to “isolat[e]” himself from Mali, who is annoying him. Thus, the quotation plants a suspicion in readers’ minds: every time Jagan turns to religion, they may wonder whether he is doing it out of genuine piety or to avoid a secular problem.

The quotation also reveals Jagan’s thoughts about the difficulty of living a genuinely religious life. He believes that “one ought to” keep praying “eternally,” but that “one could not.” In other words, at this point in the story, he believes it is impossible for a human being to live a life wholly devoted to religious practice and contemplation even though such practice and contemplation constitutes an ideal.

This quotation foreshadows the novel’s end, when Jagan will retreat to a religious shrine to live the rest of his life “praying eternally”—a retreat that may be motivated by a real religious experience or, as this quotation suggests, a desire to permanently dodge the problem that Mali poses to him.

Chapter 7 Quotes

☞ “Do you make your images there?”

At this, the man burst into a big laugh and said, “Did I not tell you what I do now? I make hair dyes. I can make the whitest hair look black.”

Related Characters: Jagan, The Bearded Man (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 110–111

Explanation and Analysis

A mysterious bearded man has come to the sweet shop, introduced himself to Jagan, and explains that he was once the apprentice to a masterful carver of religious images who lived in a shrine not far from Jagan’s. When Jagan asks whether the bearded man whether he still makes “images”—that is, religious statues—at the shrine, the bearded man laughs and explains that his occupation is now to “make hair dyes.” In other words, the bearded man has left an apprenticeship that attempts to communicate religious truth through art to enter a profession whose purpose is to “make the whitest hair look black”—that is, to practice deception and flatter customers’ vanity. The opposition between religious truth and commercial deception in the bearded man’s life story suggests that many forms of commercial activity may be hostile to living a

sincere religious life. This suggestion foreshadows how Jagan, at the end of the novel, will give up his shop and his participation in commercial activity to retire to the bearded man’s shrine.

Chapter 8 Quotes

☞ He went on talking and Jagan listened agape as if a new world had flashed into view. He suddenly realized how narrow his whole existence had been—between the Lawley Statue and the frying shop[.]

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali, The Bearded Man

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 117

Explanation and Analysis

The bearded man has taken Jagan to the religious image-maker’s shrine and is explaining the relationship of various pedestals and rejected statue parts to statues of different Hindu gods. This religious discourse makes Jagan feel that his “whole existence” has been “narrow.”

The terms that Jagan uses to describe this narrowness are literally, geographically true: he does live near “the Lawley statue” and walk from there to work at “the frying shop.” Yet the description of his life as taking place “between the Lawley statue and the frying shop” implies that he is criticizing himself for resting on his laurels when it comes to his participation in the Indian independence movement and for focusing too much on commercial activity.

The “Lawley statue” is a statue of (fictional) British colonizer Sir Frederick Lawley, which stands close to Jagan’s family home in the (fictional) southern Indian town of Malgudi. As such, it represents the history of British colonization of India, against which Jagan demonstrated until Indian independence in 1947. When Jagan suggests that the Lawley statue has marked a “narrow” boundary for his life, he seems to suggest that his ongoing preoccupation with and pride in a battle that has already been won—Indian independence—has distracted him from other battles he needs to fight, namely, the battle to perceive a “new world” of religious enlightenment. Similarly, when Jagan suggests that “the frying shop” marks the other boundary of his life, he implies that his commercial concerns have hidden this “new world” from him.

☞ “It would be the most accredited procedure according to our scriptures—husband and wife must vanish into the forest at some stage in their lives, leaving the affairs of the world to younger people.”

Related Characters: The Bearded Man (speaker), Jagan, Mali

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 123

Explanation and Analysis

The bearded man is trying to persuade Jagan to buy the shrine of his former apprentice-master, a genius carver of religious statues, as a religious retreat—and to fund the bearded man’s completion of his dead former master’s final project. As part of this persuasion, the bearded man claims that “our scriptures” encourage people who have reached a certain “stage in their lives” to retreat from the world, “leaving the affairs of the world to younger people.”

Previously, the novel has implied a conflict between Mali’s secularism, implied to be characteristic of many young men like him, and Jagan’s Hinduism, implied to be somewhat characteristic of Jagan’s generation (if not to Jagan’s degree of devoutness). On one view, the novel’s end—in which Jagan retires in a permanent religious retreat, leaving “the affairs of the world” to Mali and his generation—looks like Jagan forfeiting the conflict to secularism.

Yet on the other hand, if “vanish[ing] into the forest” is a clearly culturally legible religious act, then Jagan’s eventual retreat is not just washing his hands of Mali and his generation. Rather, it’s possible to read his retreat as an attempt to model a dignified religious path that Mali may eventually want to follow as he ages. As such, the bearded man’s quotation here further complicates the novel’s ambiguous ending, in which it is not clear whether Jagan is simply giving up on Mali and fleeing his own problems or trying to make a genuinely meaningful religious gesture.

Chapter 9 Quotes

☞ “If she has nothing to do here, she goes back, that’s all. Her air ticket must be bought immediately.”

“But a wife must be with her husband, whatever happens.”

“That was in your day,” said Mali, and left the room.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali (speaker), Grace

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 131

Explanation and Analysis

Mali has once again cornered his father Jagan to demand whether Jagan has come to a decision about funding Mali’s story-writing-machine business. In response, Jagan asks what will happen to Mali’s American girlfriend Grace—whom Mali has claimed is his wife—if Jagan refuses. Mali claims that Grace must return to the U.S. unless she has something “to do” in his business. This rather surprising claim reveals that Mali thinks of his relationship to Grace as first and foremost a business arrangement. That is, if she is not serving the needs of his business, that means she must have nothing “to do”—and if she has no commercial or employment-related reason to be in India, she shouldn’t be living there.

Mali’s attitude, which suggests that marital and romantic relationships are subordinate to commercial and business concerns, shocks Jagan, who believes that spouses should stay together regardless of their job situations: “a wife must be with her husband, no matter what.” When Mali retorts that “that was in [Jagan’s] day,” he implies that Jagan’s generation’s traditional ideas about marriage and romance no longer hold water with people of Mali’s younger generation. This exchange thus emphasizes the generational value difference between Mali and Jagan—a value difference that Mali’s story-writing machines both symbolize and bring to light.

Chapter 10 Quotes

☞ “Mo has no more use for me.”

“Use or no use, my wife—well, you know, I looked after her all her life.”

Related Characters: Jagan, Grace (speaker), Mali, Ambika

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 139

Explanation and Analysis

Jagan is hoping to salvage a relationship with Grace, the young American woman whom he believes to be his daughter-in-law, despite the breakdown in her relationship with Jagan’s son Mali. He goes to speak with Grace alone and asks her whether her potential return to the U.S. was

Mali's idea or hers. Grace tells Jagan that "Mo"—her nickname for Mali—has "no more use" for her now that she isn't working and has run out of money. Mali and Grace's acceptance of the idea that one person's "use" for their romantic partner might be exhausted if their partner no longer has money implies that, in Mali and Grace's generation, economic values have fully infiltrated interpersonal relationships.

Jagan's response indicates that he rejects this idea wholesale. When he says that he "looked after" his wife Ambika whether she had "use" or "no use," he is not simply referring to conservative gender relations where the man is the "breadwinner" who economically supports his wife keeping house. Rather, he is referring to a painful personal history in which Ambika, once an energetic pillar of the household, became extremely sick and eventually died of brain cancer. Thus, he is asserting the moral value of caring for family members who are disabled by sickness or otherwise unable to work—in contrast with Mali, who reduces Grace to her economic usefulness to him.

“Our young men live in a different world from ours and we must not let ourselves be upset too much by certain things they do.”

Related Characters: The Cousin (speaker), Jagan, Mali, Grace

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 141

Explanation and Analysis

When the cousin comes to visit Jagan's sweet shop in the afternoon as usual, Jagan immediately blurts what he learned from Grace that morning: Grace and Mali aren't married as Mali claimed. The cousin, seeing how flustered and unhappy Mali's premarital relationship has made Jagan, tells him that "young men live in a different world from ours" and that, therefore, the older generation shouldn't get "upset too much by certain things they do."

This quotation reveals that the cousin as well as Jagan feels a deep generational divide between people around his age, who remember India prior to its independence in 1947; and people around Mali's age, who were small children when India became independent and may have no memory of the colonial era. According to the cousin, the younger generation's different context has effectively created "a different world" for them, as if they do not share the same

reality as the older generation.

Jagan seems to believe that the younger generation's "different world" is illusory—that due to their different historical context, they have failed to learn something important that the older generation knows. But on the flip side, the cousin's laissez-faire attitude implies that the two generations' "worlds" are equally legitimate and so the older generation should not impose negative judgments on "certain things"—e.g. premarital sex—that the younger generation does. The cousin's attitude reveals that generational difference need not necessarily lead to generational conflict, though it does in Jagan and Mali's case.

Chapter 11 Quotes

“Grace has been getting funny notions, that's why I told you to pack her off, but you grugged the expenditure,” said Mali.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali (speaker), Grace

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 151

Explanation and Analysis

Mali has once again cornered Jagan and pressured him to declare once and for all whether he will fund Mali's business. Jagan, meanwhile, is fixated on the idea that Mali and his girlfriend Grace need to marry quickly to redeem their shameful premarital relationship. Yet when Jagan tells Mali that he can arrange a fast marriage, Mali says that "Grace has been getting funny notions" and that he wants her to leave. The terms Mali uses to express this desire show his disregard for Grace as a person and his tendency to see even interpersonal relationships in commercial terms.

It isn't clear what Mali means by Grace "getting funny notions," but two possibilities seem plausible. First, whereas the Americanized, secular Mali holds Indian culture in contempt, American Grace has repeatedly expressed enthusiasm for India and Hinduism. If Mali liked having an American girlfriend to signal his Westernized sophistication in contrast with his patriotic, religious Indian father, Grace's "funny notions"—that is, her positive reaction to India—may have annoyed Mali and cooled his feelings toward her. The second option is that Grace may be pressuring Mali to marry her as she claimed he promised to do once they reached India, in which case her "funny notions" might be her belief that she and Mali actually should marry. In either

case, Mali referring to Grace's judgments as "funny notions" shows his contempt for her and his lack of interest in her judgments and desires.

Additionally, Mali claims that he told Jagan to "pack her off" but that Jagan "grudged the expenditure"—or, in other words, that Jagan doesn't want Grace to return to the U.S. only because he is too cheap to pay for her plane ticket. This interpretation of Jagan's motives is false and unfair: he both cares about Grace and believes that she and Mali have a moral obligation to marry. Mali's assumption that Jagan's reason for wanting Grace to stay must be financial betrays that Mali's take on interpersonal relationships is exclusively financial—showing how his narrow, Westernized, capitalistic focus on money has flattened his ability to relate to others.

Chapter 12 Quotes

☛ Jagan, as became a junior, was careful not to show too much personal interest in his marriage, but he was anxious to know what was going on.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali, Grace, Ambika

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 162

Explanation and Analysis

In an extended flashback, Jagan is recalling how his older relatives helped arrange his marriage to his wife Ambika. This flashback occurs immediately after Jagan has failed to convince his son, Mali, to marry Grace, the young American woman with whom Mali has been having a premarital relationship. As such, the flashback is clearly intended to contrast Jagan's relationship with his wife Ambika to Mali's relationship with Grace.

This quotation clearly reveals generational differences in how Jagan and Mali handle their romantic relationships. Young Jagan was interested in doing "what became a junior"—i.e., he was interested in conforming to his elders' social dictates about how a younger person, a "junior," should act in a romantic relationship. Thus, while infatuated with his prospective bride and "anxious" to know how negotiations are proceeding, Jagan is "careful" to regulate his behavior.

By contrast, Mali has no interest in or respect for his elders' social dictates about how he should behave in a romantic relationship. While he does initially lie to Jagan that he and

Grace are married—presumably because he knows Jagan might not fund his business if he knew Mali and Grace were cohabiting premaritally—he displays no guilt or shame about his behavior to Jagan after Grace admits to Jagan that Mali never actually married her. Moreover, he treats Jagan's interest and attempts to interfere in his romantic life as a bizarre imposition. Thus, this quotation implicitly presents a major contrast between Jagan's and Mali's generational mores about romantic relationships.

☛ They sent out three thousand invitations. [...] Jagan's whole time was spent in greeting the guests or prostrating himself at their feet as if they were older relatives. The priests compelled him to sit before the holy fire performing complicated rites and reciting sacred *mantras*; his consolation was that during most of these he had to be clasping his wife's hand; he felt enormously responsible as he glanced at the sacred *thali* he had knotted around her neck at the most auspicious moment of the ceremonies.

Related Characters: Jagan, Mali, Grace, Ambika

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 165–166

Explanation and Analysis

In an extended flashback, Jagan recalls his wedding to Mali's mother Ambika. Jagan and Ambika's wedding creates a sharp implicit contrast between the romantic values of Jagan's generation and those of Mali and Grace's generation.

Jagan and Ambika's relationship is embedded in a larger social context: they send "three thousand invitations," a massive number, and Jagan spends much of the wedding "greeting the guests," whom he treats with tremendous respect, as if they were "older relatives." By contrast, Mali and Grace's relationship is private and atomized: Mali doesn't even tell Jagan about Grace until he brings her home to India from the U.S., and while Grace has a few unnamed friends in India, readers see her interact almost exclusively with Jagan or Mali.

In addition to being embedded in a social context, Jagan and Ambika's relationship is embedded in a religious tradition, Hinduism. Hindu priests preside over their wedding. Jagan "recit[es] sacred *mantras*" (a mantra is a repeated syllable, word, chants, or other verbal formula with a religious function, often ritual or meditative). He also gives Ambika a *thali*, a gold necklace with religious significance in Tamil

Hindu weddings. This religious context makes Jagan feel “enormously responsible” toward his wife. By contrast, secular Mali seems to feel no responsibility at all toward his girlfriend Grace, though he brought her to India and (she claims) promised to marry her there. But as soon as she becomes inconvenient to him, he wants her to return to the U.S. The contrast between Jagan and Ambika’s community-centered wedding and Mali and Grace’s atomized and secular relationship suggests that the younger generation—for better and worse—forms relationships that are much easier to end than the relationships of previous generations.

Westernize India through capitalist development. While the car didn’t “create[]” Mali’s “notions,” it is symptomatic of those notions—the same notions that may have led Mali to contemptuously flout Indian law and bring alcohol to a meeting with potential foreign business partners, as the cousin later reveals he was doing. Thus, Jagan’s antipathy toward Mali’s green car is both comic and dead serious.

“If you meet her, tell her that if she ever wants to go back to her country, I will buy her a ticket. It’s a duty we owe her. She was a good girl!”

Chapter 13 Quotes

“That’s why I discouraged his idea of buying that horrible green car!” He vented his rage against the green automobile until the cousin interrupted, “A bottle could be sneaked in anywhere . . .”

“You don’t understand. It’s the motor car that creates all sorts of notions in a young fellow,” said Jagan[.]

Related Characters: Jagan, The Cousin (speaker), Mali

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 184

Explanation and Analysis

The cousin has just rushed up to Jagan and informed him that Mali has been arrested for having alcohol in his car (alcohol was illegal in Tamil Nadu, the Indian state where the novel is implied to take place, until 1971). Jagan immediately exclaims that he “discouraged” Mali from “buying that horrible green car” for exactly that reason.

On one level, Jagan’s exclamation is intended to be funny: the novel never represented Jagan trying to dissuade Mali from buying the car, which suggests that Jagan—with the benefit of hindsight—is inventing his opposition on the spot. Moreover, the car certainly didn’t give Mali the alcohol, and Jagan’s less excitable cousin is correct to point out that “a bottle could be sneaked in anywhere.”

Yet on another level, Jagan’s antipathy toward the car makes a certain amount of sense. Mali bought the car without really needing it, as an accessory to his business ventures—rendering the car a symbol for his excessive materialism, his commercial ambitions, and his desire to

Related Characters: Jagan (speaker), Mali, Grace, The Cousin

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 191

Explanation and Analysis

At the novel’s end, Jagan decides to retire from worldly life to a religious retreat rather than involve himself with his son Mali’s upcoming trial for alcohol possession (illegal in Tamil Nadu, the Indian state where the novel implicitly takes place, until 1971). His parting words to his cousin, however, are not about Mali but about Mali’s rejected American girlfriend, Grace. This closing bit of dialogue sheds light both on Jagan’s motives for retiring to a religious retreat and his final judgment on Mali and Grace’s relationship.

First, because Jagan has been timid, avoidant, and uncommunicative with Mali and Grace for much of the novel, readers may find it difficult to decide whether his decision to retire to a religious retreat after Mali’s arrest stems from genuine religious devotion or a desire to escape interpersonal entanglements. While this quotation may not undermine readers’ belief in Jagan’s real piety, it does characterize him as chronically avoidant till the end: instead of finding Grace and offering to “buy her a ticket” directly, Jagan leaves that task to his cousin and to chance. He says, for instance, that the cousin need communicate Jagan’s offer only “if” he runs into Grace, even though Jagan claims he has a “duty” to make the offer. At the novel’s end, then, Jagan has not overcome his fearful avoidance of necessary communications.

Yet, Jagan’s final judgment on Mali and Grace’s relationship seems to be in Grace’s favor. While Grace told Jagan that Mali had promised to marry her once they reached India, Mali told Jagan that Grace was gossiping and accused her of being mentally unstable. At first, Jagan wasn’t sure whom to

believe. His conclusion here that Grace is a “good girl” to whom “we”—that is, Mali’s family—owes a “duty” implies that he has come to believe Grace’s version of events: she would have married Mali and redeemed their premarital

relationship if Mali had acted responsibly toward her. Jagan’s final judgment for Grace and against Mali further suggests that he is fleeing worldly concerns not only out of religious sentiment, but also out of disgust with his son.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

Jagan says, “Conquer taste, and you will have conquered the self,” to a man whom he considers his cousin, though it’s not clear how they’re related. When the cousin asks why you’d conquer yourself, Jagan says that “our sages” suggest it’s a good idea, though he doesn’t know why himself. The two men are sitting under a portrait of the goddess Lakshmi across from a kitchen where they can smell sweetmeats frying; each afternoon, the cousin stops into Jagan’s shop, tastes the food, and gives Jagan advice about ingredients and prices.

Jagan owns a sweet shop, yet he believes that it may be a good idea to “conquer taste” as well as “the self” because “our sages”—that is, holy or religious wise people—have suggested it. The ironic contrast between Jagan’s sweets business and his somewhat idealistic belief in self-denial hint that struggles around commercial consumption will be important going forward. Lakshmi is a Hindu goddess associated with wealth, beauty, and fertility; her portrait in the shop indicates that Jagan is Hindu and possibly—given Lakshmi’s association with wealth—that he is trying to square his worldly business pursuits with his religious beliefs.



Jagan tells the cousin that he decided to stop eating salt because people should only eat “natural salt.” The cousin asks whether “natural salt” is what dries on you after you sweat. Jagan dislikes this crude suggestion. He’s an ethereal person: a slim, balding man who rarely shaves because he thinks that staring too often in the mirror is “an intolerable European habit.” He spins yarn for an hour each day, makes his own clothes, and sells the remaining yarn—a habit he has kept up for more than 20 years, ever since Gandhi visited his town and praised his spinning.

It isn’t entirely clear what Jagan means by “natural salt”—perhaps he is talking about a no-salt-added diet—but given that he sells fried sweets, his enthusiasm for a healthy diet ironically underscores the inconsistencies between his business and his personal beliefs. Jagan’s opinion that looking in the mirror is an “intolerable European habit” indicates his disdain for Western cultural mores. His decades-long hero-worship of Mahatma Gandhi (1869–1948), the famous leader of India’s nonviolent independence movement, suggests his patriotism and perhaps his personal involvement in the movement.



Jagan used to make his own sandals from the skin of already-dead animals because, as an adherent of Gandhi’s, he doesn’t want to kill animals. As a child, Jagan’s son (Mali) enjoyed his father’s leather tanning activities, but he started whining about the smell when he got older. Jagan’s wife (Ambika) always disliked the smell and would hide in a room for days until Jagan finished a bit of tanning. On her deathbed, she mumbled something that Jagan interpreted as “throw away the leather,” so he gave away the last leather he had tanned and began commissioning his cruelty-free sandals from the Albert Mission.

Jagan’s son Mali began complaining about his father’s idiosyncratic sandal-making habits as he got older, which hints that tension between parents and children—and perhaps between generations—may be important to the novel’s plot going forward. Meanwhile, Jagan may have misinterpreted his wife’s final words as “throw away the leather”—it’s not clear what she actually said—which may foreshadow that miscommunication will also be important.



The cousin sees Jagan blush at the cousin's crude speculations about "natural salt." Amused, the cousin says soothingly how independent and austere Jagan's life is. Jagan, pleased, informs the cousin that he has given up sugar and rice too. The cousin—gesturing at Jagan's sweet shop—asks why Jagan keeps "working and earning," but then he quiets down because it's 6 p.m., when Jagan counts his money in privacy.

Though during the day the shop fills with the sound of frying while Jagan reads the *Bhagavad Gita*, it is silent when he counts the money, which a boy he employs brings in two containers at 6 p.m. and 7 p.m. Jagan talks over the day's sales with his cooks and dismisses them; then he puts away the *Bhagavad Gita* and counts his money. He keeps two accounts—one for the tax man that contains all the money that comes in the 6 p.m. bundle, and one secret account that includes the money that comes in the 7 p.m. bundle. Then he locks up his money.

CHAPTER 2

On Jagan's walk home from the store, he passes Truth Printing, the shop to which he gave his work "Natural Cure and Natural Diet" years ago. He resists the temptation to pop in and ask the printer Nataraj whether the work is ready yet. He passes a homeless man and thinks that the man's existence is a "disgrace to the nation." Then, walking up to a statue of Sir Frederick Lawley looking over the town Malgudi, Jagan begins to get excited about seeing his son Mali soon. He spots Mali with a group of friends and, though ecstatic at his son's impressive appearance, keeps walking home to avoid embarrassing him.

At home, Jagan walks through the house to the backyard bathroom, briefly glancing at and pondering the stars as he crosses the yard. The dilapidated outhouse hasn't been renovated; Jagan's own father thought there was no point in renovating a bathroom, since it's not a place where people ought to loiter. In fact, the house in general has not been renovated: "Everything in this home had the sanctity of usage, which was the reason why no improvement was possible."

Every morning at 5 a.m. Jagan wakes up, goes to the back yard, and uses a twig from his margosa tree as a toothbrush. He distrusts the bristles in commercial toothbrushes—whether made from pig bristles or nylon—and is very pleased with his father for having planted the margosa tree, which he believes will grow enough twigs "for his generation and the next."

The cousin's question about why Jagan keeps "working and earning" hammers home the inconsistencies between Jagan's austere, inexpensive life and his apparently successful sweet-shop business. Jagan's personal values seem not to align with what he sells to others.



The Bhagavad Gita is an important scripture in Hinduism. That the shop is full of distracting noise while Jagan reads scripture but silent while he counts money implies that Jagan's business isn't conducive to religious contemplation, only to profit. Meanwhile, Jagan's tax evasion indicates that he sometimes fails to put Hindu ethics—which look negatively on greed and stealing—into practice.



Jagan has apparently written a health-food book, "Natural Cure and Natural Diet"—a revelation hammering home that his fried sweets business is at odds with his personal values and practices. When Jagan thinks that the homeless man is a "disgrace to the nation," it isn't clear whether he is blaming the homeless man or politicians for the man's homelessness. But either way, it is clear that Jagan is emotionally invested in "the nation" succeeding and improving. Meanwhile, the statue of Sir Frederick Lawley—a fictional British colonizer—gestures to the history of the UK's direct colonial rule of India from 1858 to 1947.



The phrase "the sanctity of usage" implies that there is something holy about doing things the way they've always been done which precludes any "improvement." Yet while Jagan may have inherited his father's attitude toward the house, the novel has already dropped hints that Jagan has a tense relationship with his own son, Mali.



This passage reinforces Jagan's dislike of change and the continuity between his generation and his father's—paradoxically heightening readers' suspicion that conflict between Jagan's "generation and the next" (that is, Mali's generation) is coming.



Jagan's wife (Ambika) used to loathe Jagan's theories about healthy living. She became especially annoyed the time he tried to convince her to eat margosa flowers instead of taking aspirin for a headache. That day, Jagan grudgingly conceded to her preferences and went to Mali's room to ask where Ambika kept aspirin. Young Mali told him that Ambika kept it up high where she thought he couldn't reach it. Jagan, alarmed, told Mali that aspirin was poison and promised him "better things to eat than this pill."

Since the novel begins with Jagan proclaiming the virtues of conquering taste, his promise to give Mali "better things to eat" than aspirin indicates that Jagan wants to instill in his son a taste for traditional, natural remedies over modern commercial conveniences—which Jagan believes to be in some fundamental sense poisonous. Whether Mali will "conquer" any taste for modern consumer goods remains to be seen.



CHAPTER 3

One morning at breakfast, Mali tells Jagan that he is quitting college. When Jagan asks whether Mali is being bullied, Mali says school isn't "interesting." When Jagan suggests that he could go to the college and talk to someone, Mali glares. Jagan suggests that they talk about it later—though he feels he should tell Mali to go to school—because he's afraid of putting Mali off his food. Ever since Ambika was hospitalized for the first time with "brain fever," Jagan has cooked a lot for Mali—though eventually Mali insisted that he would eat in the college canteen and would only accept breakfasts from Jagan. Now Jagan asks where Mali is going to eat if he isn't in college. Mali retorts why it matters when Jagan is always saying people can go without food; then he leaves.

In this scene, Jagan repeatedly fails to communicate effectively with Mali. Ignoring Mali's implicit claim that no bullying is occurring, he offers to go to Mali's college to intervene in the (non-existent) bullying—thereby annoying his son. Then he swallows his urge to encourage his son to continue in school out of fear. Finally, he fails to get a straight answer from Mali about where Mali will eat. Thus, this scene hints that Jagan is a timid and ineffective communicator, at least when it comes to his son.



That evening, when the cousin visits Jagan in his shop, Jagan tries to call him over—but the cousin goes into the kitchen to taste the wares first. While waiting, Jagan sees schoolchildren gaping at the Sweet Mart window, but he refuses to pity them, thinking that he can't give out sweets for free. He begins thinking about poverty in India. When the cousin comes out of the kitchen, Jagan announces that people don't know how good they have it—"especially young men." He tries to quote a report he read on the subject but forgets exactly what he wanted to say.

Jagan represses any guilt he may feel about hungry children who can't afford his sweets by telling himself that his business simply doesn't allow him to distribute free sweets—a repression indicating that commercial success represses virtues like pity and generosity. Yet the hungry schoolchildren lead him to think about poverty in India, suggesting that food insecurity in India troubles his patriotic sensibilities. Interestingly, he displaces his guilt about the hungry schoolchildren by claiming that the younger generation is more privileged than it knows. That he singles out "young men" as particularly clueless and ungrateful suggests his buried annoyance with Mali.



Jagan tells the cousin about Mali's idea to quit college and explains that he'd hoped Mali would get a B.A. because he himself never did. He claims that he left college because Gandhi told him to engage in non-violent resistance, and so Jagan spent his college years in prison—omitting to mention that he had repeatedly failed the B.A. exam and dropped out of his college prior to protesting under Gandhi. Then he asks the cousin what excuse this generation has not to study. The cousin suggests Jagan talk to Mali about it; Jagan retorts that the cousin should talk to Mali and tell Jagan about it later that night, adding that Mali has called the cousin "uncle" since childhood.

At 10 p.m. that night, the cousin comes by Jagan's house, and they take a walk. The cousin explains to Jagan, who is spinning disaster scenarios in his mind, that Mali simply wants to become a writer. Jagan understands the term "writer" through the lens of British colonial rule, when "writer" meant a lowly clerk for the East India Company. He asks why Mali would want such awful work.

The cousin, not realizing that Jagan has misunderstood the word "writer," continues: he waited for Mali outside the college, where Mali was saying goodbye to his school friends, and overheard Mali telling his teachers that Jagan might send him to America. Jagan shouts, "America indeed!" and bewails Mali's strange notions. When the cousin points out that Mali could be a "Tagore or Shakespeare," Jagan suddenly realizes what kind of writer Mali wants to be. Relieved, he asks the cousin what Mali wants to write. The cousin, unsure, suggests that Mali may want to write poetry or something.

The cousin explains that when Mali finished speaking to people outside the college, the cousin invited him for coffee. At a restaurant, Mali told the cousin that he loathed the college and everything about it; at one point, Mali even ripped up a schoolbook and asked a waiter to burn the pages in the kitchen. Jagan, horrified, asks the cousin how Mali could do that when books are "a form of the goddess *Saraswathi*." When the cousin suggests that since Indian education is so poor, it makes sense to tear up books, Jagan says he hopes the cousin hasn't been talking to Mali like that. But when the cousin says that Mali composed a verse about book-burning on the spot and ate a great deal at the restaurant, Jagan is pleased again and offers to reimburse the cousin for the food.

Mahatma Gandhi led the nonviolent political movement to protest British colonial rule of India and demonstrate for self-rule from the 1920s through the 1940s, culminating in India's 1947 independence. Though Jagan dropped out of college before joining the independence movement, he seems to feel that the cultural context of his youth—in which Indians were fighting for sovereignty and self-determination—justified dropping out of college in a way that Mali's post-independence cultural context simply doesn't. Meanwhile, Jagan dodges communicating directly with his son—presumably out of fear or other awkward feelings—and manipulates the cousin into acting as a go-between instead.



The East India Company (1600–1874) was a British joint-stock company that began colonizing parts of India well before the UK officially took over India as a colony in 1858. That Jagan understands the profession of "writer" with reference to the East India Company shows how the British colonial context of his youth continues to influence his thought patterns in the post-independence context.



When Jagan cries "America indeed!", it implies that he has a negative view not only of India's former colonizer the UK, but also of the U.S. as another globally hegemonic Western cultural influence. "Tagore" refers to Rabindranath Tagore (1861 – 1941), an Indian novelist, playwright, and poet who won the Nobel Prize in 1913; William Shakespeare (c. 1564–1616) was a globally famous English playwright. That the cousin chooses both Indian and English examples of great writers for Mali to emulate shows the ongoing influence of the UK on Indian culture in the post-independence period.



Saraswathi is the Hindu goddess of education and knowledge. Jagan interprets Mali's attack on his schoolbook as a sacrilegious act, which shows both Jagan's pious Hinduism and the near-divine importance he accords to education. Yet Jagan is still pleased when the cousin tells him that Mali ate well and improvised clever verses about his book-burning, which shows that Jagan loves Mali and wants to be proud of him despite their divergent religious and generational views.



Jagan and the cousin keep walking and talking until midnight. Suddenly, a frustrated Jagan wonders aloud why Mali can't study and write at the same time. The cousin offers that Mali said studying interfered with his writing. Jagan asks whether Shakespeare had a B.A. When the cousin points out that Kalidasa didn't, Jagan retorts that Kalidasa lived 3,000 years ago and was "a village idiot" before receiving divine inspiration from Saraswathi. The cousin suggests that perhaps Mali could become "another Kalidasa."

As soon as Jagan gets the chance, he peeks through Mali's keyhole into his room. Much to Jagan's disappointment, he sees Mali sitting around glumly, doing nothing—he was hoping for some Kalidasa-esque writerly activity. He knocks hard on Mali's door. When Mali opens it, Jagan muscles past him into the room and asks whether he wants a nicer table for his writing. Mali asks how Jagan knows about the writing, and Jagan—who can see no evidence of writing in Mali's room—says that "these things become known."

Humbly, Jagan asks what Mali is working on. Snootily, Mali replies that he is working on a novel. When Jagan asks how Mali learned to write novels, Mali asks whether Jagan is grilling him. Jagan tries to ask more questions about Mali's project, but Mali claims not to know many of the answers, saying that writing isn't "like frying sweets." Jagan asks whether Mali's friends are writers too, and Mali dismisses his friends disparagingly. Jagan, who thought Mali liked his friends, thinks wonderingly how little he understands his son, whom he has known for 20 years.

Mali explains that he saw a novel-writing competition with a 25,000-rupee prize in *Ananda Vikatan*. Competitors must send in their submissions with a filled-out coupon from the magazine before September 30th. Jagan points out that it's May, and Mali retorts that he has five months. When Jagan asks whether Mali has started his novel and what it's about, Mali complains that Jagan is grilling him and doesn't believe in him.

Kalidasa (c. 4th–5th century CE) was a Sanskrit poet and playwright. Jagan is exaggerating somewhat when he says that Kalidasa lived 3,000 years ago, but his hyperbole—and his claim that Kalidasa was an "idiot" without support from the goddess Saraswathi—underscores his belief that comparing Mali, a modern young man, to Kalidasa is not appropriate and does not excuse Mali's sacrilegious assault on books.



Jagan first spies on Mali and then answers him vaguely and evasively—simply saying "these things become known"—when Mali asks how Jagan knows about his writing. Both incidents highlight Jagan's failures to communicate openly and honestly with his son.



Though Jagan does repeatedly fail to communicate with Mali openly and honestly, their communication problems are not all Jagan's fault. When Jagan does manage to ask Mali direct questions, Mali dodges them or offers unsatisfying answers. He also indirectly insults his father's business by speaking contemptuously of "frying sweets" in contrast to the (by implication) more noble pursuit of novel-writing.



Ananda Vikatan is a Tamil-language magazine that was founded in 1926 and is still published today. Mali's explanation of his writerly ambitions—that he saw a big money prize—implies that his desire to write is as much commercial as it is artistic. Meanwhile, Mali's complaints in response to basic questions from his father again emphasizes that Jagan is not solely at fault for their communication problems.



Jagan effusively claims to believe in Mali. Meanwhile, though, he wonders why an “invisible barrier” exists between him and Mali, even though Jagan has always been a kind, giving father, especially since Ambika died of a brain tumor 10 years before. He remembers Mali looking frightened and confused after the family doctor visited Ambika during the final hours of her illness, asking what the doctor had said to Jagan. Jagan abruptly broke down, “wail[ing].” Mali looked at him with confusion and “dismay”—and ever since, there has been distance between father and son.

Jagan seems to believe that the “invisible barrier” between him and Mali arose because Jagan broke down “wail[ing]” in front of Mali after Mali’s mother died—because Mali had an intense negative response to witnessing his father’s uncontrolled emotion. It isn’t clear whether Jagan is a reliable interpreter of Mali’s response: Mali may have felt “dismay” out of empathy for Jagan’s pain rather than disgust at Jagan’s emotional outburst, for example. Nevertheless, readers can infer that Jagan has limited his open, emotional communication with Mali due to Jagan’s perception that Mali was horrified by his father’s uncontrolled grief.



Jagan tells Mali again that he believes in him and that he only asked about the story because he was curious, due to his love of stories. Then he claims to be a writer himself, mentioning his book at Truth Printing. Mali asserts that he’s trying to write “something different.” Father and son continue talking deep into the night. During this conversation, Jagan learns that Mali cut the competition coupon from *Ananda Vikatan* in his college library rather than buying his own copy to get back at the college librarian, whom Mali believes is stuck up.

Unusually for Jagan, he tries here to share with Mali and identify directly with him. Yet Mali rebuffs Jagan’s attempt to share the identity of “writer” with his father, claiming that his own writing will be “something different” from whatever Jagan has done in the past. Mali’s claim of difference hints that he sees his father’s ideas as antiquated and out of touch.



At the sweet shop the next day, Jagan brags to his head cook that Mali is going to earn 25,000 rupees with a novel he’ll write by September. When the cousin arrives, Jagan tells him about Mali’s plans too and adds that he hopes Mali will “emulate [Jagan’s] philosophy of living” after he wins the prize. The cousin wonders aloud why Jagan keeps making money at business, given his philosophy of simplicity, and Jagan replies that it’s one’s duty to work—and besides, he’s supporting his employees. Then, out of nowhere, he announces that he will never use “essences for flavouring or colouring” but only natural ingredients in his shop.

When Jagan brags about Mali’s plans to his cook and to the cousin, it shows his desire to believe in Mali and be proud of him despite Mali’s hostile and sullen behavior. Yet again, the cousin asks Jagan why he keeps accumulating money despite his frugal “philosophy of living,” and Jagan gives rather unsatisfactory answers: even if it is one’s duty to work, it isn’t necessarily a duty to make a lot of money in business. Jagan’s sudden claim that he’ll never use “essences for flavouring or colouring” suggests that he’s trying unsatisfactorily to square his commitment to an austere, healthy, all-natural diet with his fried-sweet business.



CHAPTER 4

Though Jagan and Mali don’t talk much at home, Mali is happy that Jagan isn’t insisting he return to college. Meanwhile, Jagan tells himself that Mali is serving humanity by providing them with literature. “[S]ervice” has been a great ideal in Jagan’s life ever since he heard Gandhi speak in 1937 and was inspired to join the anti-colonial movement, even to the point of suffering police violence and jail time. Yet Jagan worries about what kind of manuscript Mali is writing—poetry, fiction, or philosophy—and wonders whether he’s writing in Tamil or English, while at the same time feeling totally unable to just ask Mali.

Jagan tries to understand Mali’s writerly ambitions through the lens of Jagan’s own “service” to India during the Indian independence movement, which Gandhi (1869–1948) led from the 1920s up to India’s independence in 1947. Yet given that Mali is writing after independence and has expressed commercial motives for his novel-writing, it seems likely that the patriotic and “service”-oriented motives Jagan attributes to Mali are inaccurate.



September passes, and Jagan has no idea whether or not Mali has written and sent off his novel manuscript. One day, the cousin arrives in the shop and exclaims that despite Jagan's comfortable economic circumstances, he looks "careworn." Jagan asks whether the cousin has seen Mali. When the cousin says he saw him a while ago riding his bicycle on a far-off street, Jagan tries to quiz the cousin about what Mali was doing there. The cousin encourages Jagan to ask Mali questions directly, but Jagan insists that he wants to avoid making Mali unhappy. The cousin points out that this avoidance prevents Jagan from talking to Mali.

When the cousin asks when Jagan last had a conversation with Mali, Jagan realizes it was a brief, contentless exchange more than three months ago. Rather than admit this fact, Jagan says that he and Mali keep extremely different hours. He then begs the cousin to find out from Mali where Mali has been going and what happened with the novel—without revealing that Jagan asked him to. The cousin, proud to be given a meaningful task, agrees.

After four days, the cousin comes back to the sweet shop and announces that Mali wants to travel to America to study writing. Jagan, patriotism offended, asks rhetorically whether Valmiki traveled to America to learn to write the *Ramayana*. Then he asks where Mali goes during the day. The cousin explains that Mali has been working at the Town Public Library; when Jagan asks about Mali's book, the cousin says that Mali has read about a novel-writing curriculum at an American college and plans to write his book there.

Jagan wonders aloud, "Why America?" He worries that people only eat cattle and pigs there. The cousin adds that in America the people drink a lot of alcohol and the women are shameless, getting divorced and sunbathing nude. Jagan cautions that some negative stereotypes about America may be false—but he concludes that, after all, Mali mustn't go there.

The cousin says that Mali has already gone to Madras for his passport and stolen the travel fare from Jagan's savings in the house. Jagan is pleased by Mali's independence and can-do spirit, but he asks the cousin to please stop Mali. The cousin unconvincingly agrees but reiterates that Mali has made detailed plans to leave. Jagan asks whether Mali needs any help from his father. The cousin says no—Mali has already bought his plane tickets and everything. Later that night, Jagan checks his money stash, finds that 10,000 rupees have been stolen—and then freezes when he hears Mali come in as if he himself were the thief.

Yet again, Jagan has lapsed into non-communication with Mali and attempts to get information about his son indirectly, using the cousin as a go-between. Tellingly, Jagan claims that he avoids asking Mali direct questions to keep from making Mali unhappy—which suggests that Jagan fails to communicate with his son because he fears his son's displeasure.



The cousin's question reveals that Jagan's attempts to avoid upsetting Mali actually lead to them not talking—or having much of a relationship—at all. Yet while the cousin is aware that Jagan needs to talk to Mali directly, the cousin's busybody nature allows Jagan to manipulate him into acting as a go-between anyway.



The Ramayana is an ancient Indian epic traditionally attributed to Valmiki, a Sanskrit poet. By alluding to Valmiki here, Jagan is indirectly arguing that India has its own rich, long-standing literary culture, so Indian writers don't need to learn from hegemonic Western powers like the U.S. to produce great literature.



Jagan and the cousin caricature Americans as universally meat-eating, hard-drinking, and sexually promiscuous people—a caricature hinting that people of their generation believe broad negative stereotypes about hegemonic Western powers like the U.S. This contrasts with more pro-American sentiments in Mali's generation.



Jagan neither confronts Mali directly about Mali stealing his money nor asks Mali directly whether he needs help. Instead, he checks how much money has been stolen and reacts guiltily when Mali almost catches him doing so, as if he were engaged in illicit spying. Jagan's reactions show how afraid he is to communicate directly with Mali and how this fear prevents them from having necessary conversations.



CHAPTER 5

After Mali leaves, Jagan brags to everyone that his son is heading to America. One day, he receives a brief letter from Mali stating that Mali has arrived in New York, and Jagan is so excited that he rushes into Truth Printing to tell Nataraj. When he tells Nataraj that Mali has reached America, Nataraj asks whether he received a telegram. Jagan claims that Mali is too shrewd to waste 10 rupees on a telegram when he can send a letter for 10 cents—and then asks Nataraj how much a cent is worth in rupees. After puzzling over conversion rates for a moment, Nataraj just tells Jagan that he'll give him proofs for his book soon. Jagan assures Nataraj that he knows.

Jagan leaves Truth Printing and heads for work. On the way, he stops a couple acquaintances to tell them about Mali's letter; both annoy him by offering their own ideas rather than accepting "enlightenment on the subject of America" from Mali's first-hand account. When the cousin visits Jagan's shop at 4:30 as usual, Jagan informs him of Mali's safe arrival; the cousin says that he should make an offering to Ganesha in thanks, and Jagan says he certainly will. The cousin asks what news Mali included in the letter, and Jagan replies that in America there are cars everywhere and everyone is wealthy.

Uncharacteristically, Mali communicates a great deal via letter—though he generalizes about American culture rather than sharing anything personal. Jagan reads and re-reads these letters, which supplant his daily *Bhagavad Gita*, and forces information about America on everyone around him. He even gives his acquaintances a blow-by-blow of the Kennedy assassination.

After three years, however, Jagan receives a letter whose contents he does not share with anyone: in it, Mali says that he has started eating beef and suggests that Indians should start killing and eating their cows rather than taking any American food aid. Jagan, horrified, tries to figure out how to express his outrage. Jagan is still trying to figure out how to express his horror when he receives a cable from Mali saying that he is coming home with someone else.

Jagan, perplexed, goes to meet Mali's train with the cousin. When Mali appears, he seems taller than before and surrounded by fancy possessions. He introduces the woman with him, Grace, as his wife. Jagan is shocked: Mali never said that he was married. Moreover, Grace looks Chinese, and China has just violated Indian borders. Jagan wonders whether Grace might be Japanese instead but is too afraid of offending this new, fancy-looking Mali to ask.

Telegrams arrive considerably more quickly than letters. Jagan attributes Mali's choice of letter over telegram to his financial sense, but the novel seems to be implying that Mali just doesn't care about corresponding promptly with his father—another detail that shows how Mali contributes to the failures of communication between him and his father.



Ganesha, also known as Ganesh, is the Hindu god of (among other things) beginnings; when the cousin and Jagan agree that Jagan should make offerings to Ganesha, it suggests both their devotion and their desire that Mali make a good start in America. Meanwhile, Jagan's belief that he can offer "enlightenment on the subject of America" to others after one letter from Mali shows that his beliefs and opinions about America are based more on his own relationships, commitments, and prejudices than on evidence.



*U.S. President John F. Kennedy (1917 – 1963) was assassinated on November 22, 1963, indicating that this portion of the novel takes place in the early 1960s. That Jagan reads Mali's letters instead of the *Bhagavad Gita* as usual shows how his worldly and familial concerns now interfere with his religious practice.*



Cows are sacred in Hinduism, and due to Hinduism's emphasis on nonviolence toward all living creatures, religious vegetarianism is common in India. Mali's decision to start eating beef shows his Western-influenced secularism in contrast with Jagan's patriotic and religious vegetarianism.



China invaded India in October 1962, starting the Sino-Indian War; the reference to China violating India's borders, like the earlier reference to the Kennedy assassination, places the narrative's events in the early to mid-1960s (likely late 1963 or early 1964). Jagan's shock at Mali's marriage to an ethnically East Asian woman shows his conservatism in contrast with Mali's more modern cultural mores.



On the taxi ride home, the driver talks about the availability or lack thereof of various cars in India, while Mali periodically declares that “nothing has changed.” Meanwhile, Grace stares out the window happily. When she exclaims at the town’s loveliness, Mali says, “Honey, live in it and see what it is like.” Jagan wonders whether her name is Grace or Honey.

Mali’s disdainful claim that “nothing has changed” in his hometown after years of absence suggests that he thinks the town—as well as India as a whole, perhaps—is insufficiently committed to modern values of continuous progress. Grace’s exclamations over the scenery’s beauty suggest a somewhat condescending, tourist-like attitude toward India. When Mali uses the American endearment “honey” to refer to Grace, it confuses Jagan about Grace’s actual name—suggesting that Mali’s adoption of American cultural norms will lead to further communication problems between him and Jagan.



When they reach the house, Jagan becomes anxious, as he spent a lot of money in the past two weeks renovating the house with an indoor bathroom by Mali’s bedroom. Mali goes to wash up while the cousin and the driver handle Mali’s luggage, leaving Grace alone with Jagan. He offers to get her anything she likes, not knowing what exactly she needs. She praises his kindness. Yet after another awkward exchange, Jagan excuses himself by saying he has to go mind his shop and flees.

Neither Jagan’s father nor Jagan himself ever bothered to renovate the house before, feeling that “usage” had made it sacred—yet Jagan has renovated the house in preparation for Mali’s arrival. This step shows Jagan’s desire to please Mali despite not agreeing with Mali’s Americanized, secular outlook on life.



As the days pass, Jagan starts dodging his acquaintances because he doesn’t want to explain who Grace is. The cousin, curious whether Mali and Grace eat meat in Jagan’s house, asks indirect questions about how the household cooks; Jagan says that he provides what he usually does and that even the *Bhagavad Gita* says that “one can only do one’s duty up to a point.” The cousin takes Jagan’s renewed interest in the *Bhagavad Gita* as a sign of his resurgent psychological distress.

Jagan’s confusion and shame over his American daughter-in-law indicate that while people of Mali’s generation might accept interreligious marriages, people of Jagan’s and the cousin’s generation will be curious and disapproving about whether Grace eats meat (Hinduism advocates vegetarianism). Jagan’s claim that “one can only do one’s duty up to a point” may foreshadow that there are actions he will refuse to take on Mali’s behalf, despite his eager desire to please his son. Meanwhile, the cousin’s supposition that Jagan’s renewed piety is a sign of psychological distress shows that the cousin views religion as a kind of mental crutch, in contrast with Jagan’s genuine devoutness.



Every so often, one of Mali’s old friends will visit and talk quietly with Mali; Jagan, who can’t hear what they’re saying, wants to join the conversation but worries it would be “presumptuous.” Instead he wanders close by, hoping to be included, while Mali shows off various American items from his packages. (One of the packages included a picnic basket that Grace presented to Jagan as a gift, but as Jagan had no idea what to do with it, he just put it away.) Mali is always sulking in his room wearing European clothes; when he goes out with Grace, he acts “like a celebrity avoiding the attention of the rabble.”

It might be reasonable enough for Jagan to join a conversation in his own home, yet he fears that Mali will find him “presumptuous” for trying to talk to his son and his son’s friends—another instance of Jagan’s fears preventing him from communicating. Meanwhile, Mali wears European clothes and acts like a “celebrity” when he leaves the house, actions that imply his Westernization and his sense that his time in America makes him an important, noteworthy person.



One day, Grace enters Jagan's side of the house and starts cleaning. When he tries to stop her, she proclaims, "I must not forget that I'm an Indian daughter-in-law." Jagan tries again to stop her, but she points out that she has nothing else to do. As she cleans, she praises the beauty of the house. Another day, she asks to cook for Jagan. He explains that he only eats what he cooks for himself. When she responds to this idea enthusiastically, he finds himself telling her about his salt- and sugar-free diet and the health book he is writing. She tells him it will be a "best seller."

Soon Jagan, uncomfortable, asks Grace whether Mali earned his degree in America. Grace, surprised, asks whether Jagan doesn't know. Jagan says that he and Mali haven't had time to discuss it yet. Grace says Mali should have mentioned it and declares that she'll ask Mali to talk to Jagan about it. When Jagan says that Mali only informed him about America in his letters, not about personal things, Grace laughs and asks to see the letters. Jagan, hesitantly, brings the letters to her. She points to the signature, "GM," and explains that it stands for Grace and Mali—Grace is actually the one who wrote the letters.

Jagan, uncomfortable, says he couldn't have known—he didn't know about Grace. When Grace asks whether Mali ever wrote his own letters to Jagan, Jagan lies and says that Mali only wrote that he was going to marry, not whom. All Jagan knows is that Grace is "a good girl." When Grace asks whether he needs to know more, Jagan says that in India it's normal to inquire about people's backgrounds.

Grace claims that in other countries, only bureaucrats care about people's backgrounds, but since she's "Indian now," she explains that she's the daughter of a Korean woman and an American G.I. who served in Asia after World War II. Her father took her mother to New Jersey on leave and abandoned her there. Eventually, Grace went to Michigan to study domestic science, where "Mo" (Mali) was taking creative writing. They met at a football game. Abruptly, Grace asks whether Jagan is pleased. When Jagan nods, she admits that she was scared to come to India because she'd heard about the caste system and thought people might reject her. Jagan, trying to be kind, tells her vaguely that Gandhi was against the caste system and that it's in decline.

Whereas Mali wears European clothes and presents himself as an Americanized sophisticate, Grace seems eager to identify as an "Indian daughter-in-law"—which may foreshadow conflict between the two. While Jagan often avoids communicating with Mali out of fear, Grace brings him out of his shell by praising his ideas and predicting that his book will be a "best seller." The conversation shows that Jagan is just timid rather than naturally uncommunicative.



Readers may have been surprised when the sullen, rather uncommunicative Mali wrote so many letters to his father. Now the mystery is resolved: Grace, not Mali, was the one composing the letters. Grace's surprise that Mali hasn't told Jagan about his degree and her earlier insistence on writing letters to Jagan suggests that she values communication and family—which may foreshadow conflict between her and Mali.



When Jagan lies about Mali writing him letters separate from Grace's, it indicates that he knows that his and Mali's communication is unusually sparse and is ashamed of this fact. When Grace questions whether Jagan needs to know anything about her background, meanwhile, it may indicate that Grace is hiding something—or may simply indicate generational and national differences between the two characters in how important they consider a person's background to be.



Grace's surprising claim that she is "Indian now" again suggests that while Mali wants to identify with the U.S. and the West, Grace wants to identify with Mali's family and home country—another possible future source of conflict between them. Though the novel does not state this explicitly, Grace's desire to assimilate into Mali's family may be due to her American father's abandonment, which might have left her feeling disconnected from the U.S. and without as much family as she would have liked. The Indian caste system is a birth-based social hierarchy dividing people into groups called castes; Grace may have worried that she would face social exclusion in India because she has no caste. Jagan's reference to his hero Gandhi here suggests that he is trying to rationalize Grace's acceptance into his family based on authentically Indian, patriotic principles.



One day, Mali rushes up to Jagan and asks him to get a telephone for the house. When Jagan says he's never considered getting a telephone, Mali replies that he was unable to give his "associates" a home phone number, which humiliated him. Jagan asks what associates Jagan is talking about, and Mali calls Grace to join them for a "business" conversation. Mali leads Jagan to the hall, where Grace has placed some margosa shoots in a vase. Jagan, suddenly emotional, informs Grace that margosa "is the ambrosia mentioned in our Vedas." Grace, excited, repositions the flowers reverently.

Jagan, examining Mali up close, sees that Mali looks unwell. He suddenly notices that Mali is wearing socks with his sandals and thinks in horror that socks interfere with heat dispersal and with "beneficial magnetic charges" from the ground, thus causing more heart attacks in European countries, as he explains in his book. While he is thinking furiously about socks, Mali is talking at length. Jagan only zones back in to Mali's monologue at the end, when Mali says, "You get it?" Jagan, unable to answer, makes ambiguous noises. Mali tells Jagan to think about it and leaves the house to check on more baggage arriving at the train station. Afterward, Grace asks Jagan whether he has any more questions. Jagan suggests they can always talk about it again.

Though Mali went to the U.S. to study creative writing, his references to "associates" and "business" imply that he has returned with commercial rather than artistic aspirations. The Vedas (composed c. 1500 BCE – 900 BCE) are the oldest extant Hindu scriptures; Jagan's reference to these scriptures emphasizes his devout Hinduism, while Grace's excited reaction shows her naïve enthusiasm for Indian culture and her desire to assimilate into Mali's family.



On one of the few occasions where Mali attempts to communicate with Jagan at length, Jagan becomes violently distracted by Mali's socks, which Jagan thinks of as a fundamentally unhealthy European garment. This comic scene shows that Jagan's patriotism and anti-Western sentiments as well as his interpersonal timidity inhibit his ability to communicate with and understand his pro-Western son.



CHAPTER 6

At the sweet shop, the cousin makes conversation about a fight at the market because he's noticed Jagan doesn't want to discuss Mali. Jagan complains that the other merchants raising prices have no "sense of service" and notes that one man can only eat or wear so much, no matter how rich he is. The cousin jovially tells Jagan that he doesn't know how to live—yet he still gets rich! Jagan decides to repay the cousin for his flattery with information about Mali: he mentions that Mali has talked to him about his plans.

Jagan's limited parceling-out of information about Mali to the cousin shows that he is a poor communicator not only when afraid but also when upset. Meanwhile, Jagan's claim that the other merchants have "no sense of service" indicates that he thinks businesspeople have a responsibility to their customers over and above their bottom line—a somewhat controversial belief in business contexts. Finally, Jagan's argument that people only need so much is a common-sense argument against capitalism's preference for indefinite accumulation and economic growth.



After a digression in which Jagan and the cousin discuss how Mali seems to have borrowed a friend's scooter, the cousin asks whether Jagan likes Mali's "scheme." Jagan, startled by the word scheme, asks one of his employees to get rid of the children staring at the sweets in the shop window, who make him feel obscurely guilty. Meanwhile, the cousin—who has felt cold-shouldered by Jagan not talking about Mali with him—is pleased to be able to give him news. He explains that he encountered Mali at a friend's house, and Mali told him he plans to "manufacture **story-writing machines**."

The word "scheme" carries negative connotations, which may be why it shocks Jagan. Jagan's guilt over the children staring in the shop window, meanwhile, indicates that he is not living up to his own ideal of businesspeople as public servants—to make money, he has priced poorer potential customers out of buying his sweets. And finally, Jagan learns of Mali's plans to "manufacture story-writing machines"—a bizarre, science-fictional object—from the cousin rather than Mali himself. That was because when Mali told him about the machines, Jagan was distracted by Mali's socks, an odd detail suggesting that the machines may come to symbolize the various failures of communication between Jagan and Mali.



The cousin, noting Jagan's confusion with pleasure, asks whether he's never heard of the **story-writing machines** in America. Jagan admits he hasn't and asks how the machine writes stories. The cousin says that, not being an engineer, he has no idea—but Mali said it was "'electronic' or 'electric' or something like that." He suggests that Jagan ask Mali about it.

The "story-writing machines" are American, so—if they do come to symbolize Jagan and Mali's failure of communication—they may represent how those failures spring from Mali's generation's Westernization in contrast with Jagan's Indian patriotism. The cousin's inability to explain how the science-fictional machines work, meanwhile, emphasizes that readers are supposed to take the machines symbolically, as a novelistic device, rather than as any kind of real-world object.



The next morning, when Grace comes to clean Jagan's side of the house, Jagan asks her whether Mali is free to talk. Grace goes to ask, comes back, and tells Jagan Mali will talk to him in 15 minutes. Annoyed to be kept waiting, Jagan recalls when Mali used to beg him for money—but at the appointed time, he goes to Mali's room and asks how the **story-writing machine** works. Mali says that he already explained it. When Jagan admits that he didn't fully comprehend, Mali gives him a condescending look, pulls an "object that looked like a radio cabinet" out of a package, and tells him that the object can write stories using knobs, "a transistor," and "ordinary valves."

Mali's vague invocations of knobs, "a transistor," and "valves"—none of which explain how the machine works, only what parts it has—hint that Mali may not know how the machine works either but is hiding this fact from his father. Thus, the machine represents another failure of communication between Mali and Jagan: this time, Mali is deceiving Jagan about his own knowledge because he wants to appear worldly, modern, and technologically savvy in contrast with his father, whom he implicitly views as old-fashioned.



Jagan asks Mali whether he actually wants to write using the **story-writing machine**. Mali says he will not only write with it but manufacture and sell it in India to redress India's "backward" publishing industry: whereas America has 10,000 new books every year, India has only "old stories" like *Ramayana* and *Mahabharata*. Jagan cautiously approaches the peculiar device, reading labels on various parts of the machine for manipulating characters, emotions, climaxes, and so forth, and asks how you can compose a story with it. Mali replies that it's just like using a typewriter.

When Jagan asks whether Mali really wants to write using the machine, the question implies that there is something disappointing and unoriginal about using a mass-produced machine to standardize one's artistic choices. Mali's enthusiastic affirmation, in which he praises the U.S. publishing industry for producing a large number of new books while criticizing time-tested classics of Indian literature as "old stories," suggests that he values novelty, quantity, and commerce over artistic quality—values he may hold as a representative of a generation more interested in U.S.-oriented global capitalism than Jagan's.



Grace enters the room and says to Jagan how intelligent Mali is. Jagan, wondering what exactly Mali's scheme is, tells Grace that the Indian epics were composed orally and not written down for generations. Dismissively, Mali interrupts to say that in the modern era, India must compete with "advanced culture" in art as well as commerce. He tells Jagan that he may have to give up his business and come work for Mali in an office. When Jagan asks whether people actually compose stories on **story-writing machines** in America, Mali and Grace assure him that many do.

Mali tells Jagan that if they raise \$51,000, their American backers will give them help worth \$200,000 to start the business, including aid in setting up the factory and running it for the first half year. Jagan asks what Grace studied in college; she reminds him that she studied domestic economy. When Mali asks why Jagan's interested in that, Jagan says he was curious whether Grace had studied business too. Then he leaves.

When the cousin enters the sweet shop that afternoon, Jagan asks him what \$50,000 is in rupees. The cousin says "two lakhs"—a conversion he checked after talking to Mali. Jagan asks where Mali expects to get the money, and the cousin replies that Mali expects it from Jagan, whom he believes to be rich. Heatedly, Jagan exclaims that he only maintains his shop to support his employees and that "money is an evil." The cousin asks whether he's going to throw away the jug where he collects his money—and they laugh. Then Jagan asks the cousin to tell Mali that Jagan doesn't have the money. When the cousin suggests that Jagan tell Mali directly, Jagan says he doesn't want to upset Mali.

At home, Jagan feels that Mali and Grace are now putting themselves in his path and looking at him significantly. One day after breakfast, Mali comes into the *puja* room while Jagan is praying and tells him that people use electronic machines for all kinds of tasks now. Eventually, Grace summons Mali away so that Jagan can keep praying, and Jagan thinks: "Prayer was a sound way of isolating oneself—but sooner or later it ended: one could not go on praying eternally, though one ought to." He begins avoiding Mali and especially Grace at home—he's simultaneously glad that Grace cares about Mali's future and suspicious that she has organized Mali's campaign to get his money.

Jagan tries to explain to Grace a different, older, authentically Indian form of artistic production—only for Mali to interrupt him and implicitly claim that India is not yet an "advanced culture." Mali's interruption exemplifies the failures in communication between Mali and Jagan, while Mali's valorization of modern, mechanized cultural production shows his pro-Western, capitalist values. As such, this exchange further emphasizes that the story-writing machines symbolize a breakdown in communication between father and son due to their different generations and values.



"Domestic economy" is another phrase for "home economics." Jagan's question is sarcastic: he is pointing out that neither Grace nor Jagan—who studied creative writing, after all—has an academic background in business. Yet rather than making this point directly, he subtly insults Mali and Grace before walking out—yet another failure of direct communication.



A lakh is equal to 100,000 rupees. Mali has requested a huge amount of money from Jagan—huge especially given that the novel takes place in the early to mid-1960s—on the assumption that Jagan has it, without directly asking whether he does. And yet again, Jagan asks the cousin to communicate to Mali that Jagan doesn't have the money rather than doing so himself. These incidents exemplify the circuitous and ineffective way that Jagan and Mali speak with each other. Meanwhile, Jagan claims that "money is an evil" while running a fairly lucrative business—and laughs when the cousin suggests throwing out his money jug. This scene suggests that while Jagan may recognize that earning lots of money isn't necessary to a good life, he isn't yet living in accord with that abstract knowledge.



Puja is a devotional prayer practice in Hinduism; a puja room is thus a mandated religious space. Jagan is using the puja room and his prayers in part to "isolat[e] himself" and so avoid Mali and Grace. This questionable use of religious practice shows that while Jagan is genuinely devout, he also deploys his religion instrumentally to avoid his worldly and familial problems. Meanwhile, his avoidant behavior underscores yet again his difficulties with direct communication.



One day, while Jagan is walking to work, the homeless man by the statue asks him for money. Jagan gives the man a small coin, and the man asks why Jagan doesn't talk to him about America anymore and asks how Mali is doing. Jagan tersely says that Mali is going to found a factory for machines of some kind and makes his escape. Then he ducks into Truth Printing and asks Nataraj about his book. Nataraj says he'll do it as soon as he's less busy—Mali has hired him to print a "prospectus" for his business to be delivered in three days. Nataraj shows Jagan the prospectus, which lists Jagan as "one of the principal promoters of Mali Enterprises." When Nataraj asks whether Jagan isn't happy, Jagan claims he is and flees.

Nataraj seems to be delaying printing Jagan's book indefinitely, whereas he prints a business prospectus for "Mali Enterprises" at great speed. The sharply diverging ways in which Nataraj treats Mali's and Jagan's projects suggests that people are far more respectful of commercial enterprises like Mali's than they are of projects devoted to health and spirituality like Jagan's. Meanwhile, Jagan flees from conversations with the homeless man and with Nataraj when they ask him upsetting questions, showing yet again his tendency to avoid any kind of difficult conversation.



Jagan reaches the sweet shop and opens the *Bhagavad Gita*, but all he can think about is Mali's prospectus. He's angry that Mali didn't tell him about putting his name on the prospectus, yet he wonders whether he should take it as a sign of Mali's trust in him. Soon Jagan is seeing the prospectus all over town; it claims that India is backward and that the **story-writing machines** will bring progress to the country. Mali stops riding a borrowed scooter and starts driving a **green car**. One morning, while Jagan is praying, Grace comes and tells him that the company bought the car used for business travel. Jagan asks a few polite questions and then meditates until Grace goes away.

Jagan cannot concentrate on reading the Bhagavad Gita, a Hindu scripture, because he's upset about Mali, showing how worldly concerns distract even devoutly religious people from their spiritual concerns. Mali's rather contemptuous references to India's "backwardness" indicate that the story-writing machines represent his generation's pro-Western, pro-capitalist leanings in contrast with the Indian patriotism Jagan's generation grew up with. As Mali does not yet have a business, his buying a car for "business travel" seems to represent his commercialism and desire for material status symbols in contrast with Jagan's simple lifestyle.



Jagan decides that he will use "non-violent non-cooperation" of the sort he learned from Gandhi to deal with Mali and Grace. One morning, Grace asks him whether he's come to a decision about investing in the company. Rather than answer, he comments on the jasmine flower in her hair. She tells him since it's Friday and she's a "Hindu wife," she has cleaned and put flour on the threshold. Jagan wants to retort that no real Hindu wife would wear a bob like Grace's; instead, he asks how she knew Fridays are "auspicious." She says her friends tell her these things.

Jagan decides to use "non-violent non-cooperation" against Mali and Grace as if they were British colonizers, which implies that he subconsciously sees his Americanized son and Mali's American romantic partner as representatives of another destructive, hegemonic Western power. Grace, meanwhile, is clearly trying to assimilate into Mali's family. Rather than directly expressing his displeasure with her, Jagan asks how she knows that Fridays are "auspicious"—that is, holy and lucky—in Hinduism. When he swallows his real, negative feelings, it shows yet again how averse he is to direct confrontation.



Mali calls to Jagan before Jagan can escape. When Jagan enters Mali's room, Mali asks whether Jagan has come to a decision. Jagan says that Mali put his name on the prospectus without notifying him, and Mali retorts that Jagan agreed to have his name on the prospectus when Mali first explained the business to him. Jagan—knowing that he may well have done so in his zoned-out state—counters that he thought Mali might ask again before printing the prospectus. Mali groans that nothing gets done in India because people dither and redo things like that. Jagan, recalling India's cultural heritage and his own struggles for independence, tells Mali not to blame India for everything.

Jagan usually avoids expressing direct disagreement with Mali. Yet when Mali criticizes India yet again for—in his view—failing to adhere to Western business norms, the patriotism that the Indian independence movement fostered in Jagan leads Jagan to speak out in India's defense. This fact shows that Jagan is not entirely awed by his son, and that their differing views on Indian culture versus Western culture are a major part of their ongoing personal conflict.



Mali tells Jagan that they need the money soon or their business associates will back out. Jagan claims he has no money but offers Mali the sweet-shop business. Mali contemptuously refuses, saying he has higher aspirations than selling sweets. Jagan stands up to go; seeing Grace's unusually expressionless face, he wonders whether she is truly "a good girl or a bad one." On his way to the shop, the homeless man stops him. Jagan complains that he has no money, and the man chides him not to talk about himself like that. Jagan thinks that the homeless man is kinder to him than Mali is.

Jagan is already subconsciously conflicted about his sweet-shop business because it's too lucrative and worldly; by contrast, Mali believes the sweet shop isn't lucrative enough. This contrast shows how Mali—and the generation he represents—is much more gung-ho about capitalism and wealth accumulation than the previous generation. Meanwhile, Jagan's curiosity about whether Grace is a "good girl or a bad one" seems to stem from his uncertainty about whether she truly wants to assimilate into his and Mali's family or not, and whether she is truly as well-disposed toward Jagan himself as she has seemed.



When the cousin enters the sweet shop that afternoon, he sees Jagan looking miserable and so praises the quality of that day's sweets. Jagan, smiling, says he only uses "pure," quality ingredients. The cousin asks why Jagan started this particular business anyway, and Jagan explains that he was given a cooking job while in jail and decided to keep at it after his release, in particular to offer "pure sweets" to "poor children." Abruptly, he announces that he's going to lower his prices. The cousin asks about his profits, but Jagan retorts that he has "enough."

If Jagan did in fact start his business to offer "pure sweets" to "poor children," he has not lived up to his ideal: at various moments in the novel, readers have seen Jagan react guiltily to children outside the shop window who are too poor to buy the sweets inside. Jagan's decision to live up to his past ideal and lower prices comes right after Mali has derided the sweet shop as economically small potatoes. It seems that Jagan is reacting against Mali's commercial-mindedness by becoming less concerned with wealth and commercial success.



The cousin asks whether Jagan plans to give up his business, and Jagan says that Mali isn't interested in taking over for him. The cousin tells Jagan that there's no better way to make money than the sweet-shop—but Mali has his own "ideas." Jagan says that money is "evil" and that it's enough for a business to be "self-supported" without it making additional profits. Then he orders one of his employees to give free sweets packets to the children staring in the shop window. The cousin, alarmed, warns Jagan not to make any rash decisions and offers to speak with Mali and Grace. Jagan says that the cousin can speak with them about whatever he likes—but Jagan isn't asking him to.

The cousin makes vague reference to Jagan's "ideas," indicating Jagan's long-held interest in self-restraint and health in contrast with his lucrative sweet-shop business. When Jagan declares money is "evil" and that businesses should make only enough in profits to be "self-supported," he is rejecting the logic of indefinite wealth accumulation characteristic of Western capitalism that Mali seems to have accepted. Yet rather than telling Mali or Grace what he is doing and why, Jagan refuses to speak with them—showing yet again how consistently he fails at directly communicating with the people close to him.



CHAPTER 7

When the cousin comes to the shop two days later, Jagan has lowered the price of every sweets packet to “25 paise.” Many people buy from the shop, and the store runs out of sweets by 5 p.m. Jagan tells his alarmed employees that they can go home now that the sweets are sold—but that the shop won’t lower the number or caliber of sweets it produces. When one employee asks how they’ll manage, the cousin interjects that the shop is experimenting with new practices to stay competitive. The employees ask whether they should start making more sweets to meet increased demand now that the prices are lower, but Jagan says they’ll act as usual for the next 15 days and see how things go.

Jagan tells his employees that he’ll teach them how to spend their increased free time profitably and announces that he’ll read them the *Bhagavad Gita* for an hour every day. After reading the first few lines, Jagan says that Gandhi read the *Gita* to his followers daily because it is a book to be read continually, not just once—as the fight against England was continual.

Jagan keeps reading, boring his employees, until three visitors unexpectedly arrive: the owner of the Ananda Bhavan restaurant, the owner of the law courts canteen, and a bearded man whom Jagan doesn’t know. After some polite introductory chitchat, the Ananda Bhavan owner asks why Jagan has lowered his prices. When Jagan says it’s so more people can enjoy sweets, the Ananda Bhavan owner implies that Jagan is harming other food vendors.

Jagan says he’ll send his customers to his visitors’ shops if his visitors adhere to “pure quality.” The Ananda Bhavan owner says that he was able to purchase good ingredients at reasonable prices back in 1956, but not anymore. Jagan, quoting the *Gita*, says that determined people can find what they’re looking for and offers to help his visitors get good ingredients. The canteen owner quotes the *Gita* in return, saying that it tells people to do their duty “in the right spirit and the right measure”—then he asks straight out whether Jagan is doing that. Jagan can’t answer. Then the Ananda Bhavan owner says in a dead-serious tone that if Jagan lowers his prices, the others will be expected to as well—does he want that?

As there are 100 paise in a rupee, Jagan has set his prices very low. He expresses more idealism than economic logic when he declares that the shop will keep selling sweets at extremely low prices while maintaining extremely high product quality. Notably, in this scene both the cousin and Jagan fail at direct and honest communication: the cousin lies to Jagan’s employees about his purposes, while Jagan delays giving his employees any actionable information about his long-term plans for the shop. Presumably, both men are motivated by fear of upsetting or angering the employees.



When Jagan suggests that his employees ought to read the Bhagavad Gita in their free time, he is implicitly claiming that unnecessary commercial activity eats up time that would be better spent in religious contemplation. The comparison he draws between reading the Gita and fighting British colonial rule, meanwhile, may suggest that Jagan sees practicing Hinduism as a form of asserting an Indian cultural identity in the face of global capitalism.



The implicitly hostile visit from the Ananda Bhavan owner and the canteen owner shows that Jagan is bucking economic cultural norms by setting his prices so low—and, as such, confusing, frightening, and angering other businesspeople.



Jagan insists that he will only cooperate with the other businessmen if they sell food of “pure quality,” a caveat that reminds readers of how Jagan’s quasi-spiritual obsession with healthy eating ironically coexists with his fried sweets business. When the canteen owner alludes to the Gita and says it instructs people to act “in the right spirit and the right measure,” he is criticizing Jagan’s behavior as improperly motivated and extremist. Jagan’s inability to answer this accusation suggests that he may, in fact, be acting out due to his hostile feelings toward Mali and Grace rather than genuinely following his personal or religious values.



Jagan, confused, asks an employee to fetch sodas for his visitors. The Ananda Bhavan owner suggests that they finish talking business first. He says that the assembled businessmen are so beset by problems that it would make sense to close down their shops, but they can't do that to their poor customers. When Jagan asks what these problems are, the incredulous Ananda Bhavan and canteen owners complain about tax inspectors, health inspectors, and government regulations about announcing their "frying medium"—when substitutes for "pure butter-melted ghee" are now barely less expensive than ghee itself. Jagan asks why they don't just use ghee, then—massively annoying the owners.

Jagan's employee comes back with the sodas. When the Ananda Bhavan owner asks why Jagan isn't having one, Jagan says that he only drinks four ounces of water daily. He is beginning to explain how he began this practice while in jail when his visitors interrupt him. The Ananda Bhavan owner and canteen owner suggest that it's fine if Jagan wants to temporarily lower prices, but if he intends to do it for a long time, that's another thing entirely—and they're planning "on [his] cooperation." Jagan, not understanding, says he's all for cooperation. The visitors leave.

A bit later, the bearded man comes back into the shop. He introduces himself to Jagan; he used to be called "Chinna Dorai" to distinguish him from his master "Peria Dorai—the small master and the big master." When Jagan asks him about his master, the bearded man asks how many temples Jagan has visited. Jagan claims to have visited many, and the bearded man tells him that the gods in "temples all over the south" (that is, sculptures of the gods) were produced by his master. Jagan feels abruptly sorry that he's been too busy with business to visit a temple for a long time. He assures the bearded man of his piety and sings some hymns by *Sambhandar*.

After some further chat, Jagan asks the bearded man where his master lived. The bearded man says it's relatively nearby, offers to take Jagan there sometime, and then asks whether Jagan crosses the river. Jagan regretfully considers how many years he has spent going only between his house and the sweet shop and thinking only about Mali, the cousin, and his business. He remembers how, in his youth, he listened to Gandhi give inspiring speeches and tells the bearded man that Gandhi was his master. The bearded man, apparently uninterested in any master but his own, asks when Jagan can come with him to his master's place. Jagan says he'll come tomorrow.

The Ananda Bhavan owner and the canteen owner both see themselves as victims of an oppressively regulated economic system who only continue in business out of charity toward their clients. Ironically, then, they may be conceding Jagan's point: that it is better not to chase wealth and business success than it is to subject oneself to fruitless anxiety in search of profits.



The restaurant owners' lack of interest in Jagan's ideas about health and their threatening demands for "cooperation" show how a focus on success in business makes people narrow-minded and unkind. Jagan doesn't understand that he's being threatened, which shows his naivete and lack of cutthroat business instincts.



Sambhandar (also spelled Sambandar) is an ancient Tamil poet (c. 7th century C.E.) who composed numerous hymns to Shiva, the Hindu god of destruction. Jagan regrets how his business interests have diverted his attention from visiting temples and sings hymns by Sanbhandar to prove his piety, showing his embarrassment at his own inconsistent religious devotion.



Jagan's worldly and familial cares have distracted him from both his religion and his patriotic political ideals, represented in this passage by his youthful devotion to Mahatma Gandhi. His decision to visit the image-maker's shrine may be an attempt to make up for neglecting more intense religious practices.



Jagan asks the bearded man whether he carves his own images at his master's place. The bearded man, laughing, explains that he now fashions hair-dyes—and the Ananda Bhavan owner is his most regular customer. When he says he's glad to have met Jagan, Jagan says he's glad to have met "an image-maker"—and the bearded man says Jagan hasn't met one now, "only a blackener of white hair." He asks whether Jagan needs his hair dyed, and Jagan—alarmed at how Mali and Grace might react, supposing they even noticed—gently declines. Then, remembering his book, he tells the bearded man that diet determines whether one's hair ever grays.

Though the bearded man has trained to carve religious images, he now considers himself "only a blackener of white hair"—that is, someone who practices cosmetic deceptions and caters commercially to others' vanity. The bearded man's self-deprecation suggests that he would prefer to be an image-maker but that he feels he needs to make money—another instance of commercial needs or motives interfering with religious practice.



CHAPTER 8

The next day, the bearded man brings Jagan to a remote shrine by a pond in overgrown, wooded surroundings. When Jagan notes how silent the area is, the bearded man replies that you can hear traffic noise now—it used to be that you wouldn't meet a soul in these mountains but would only see people if you walked all the way into town. Jagan asked why he and his master lived up here, and the bearded man explains that the stone available nearby was good for carving.

The shrine used to be quieter but is now disturbed by traffic noise. This fact is symbolic of how the new generation's focus on commercial activity is crowding out religious contemplation and other spiritual activities.



When Jagan asks how the master fed his family up here, the bearded man explains that the master had no family—he adopted the bearded man when the man was five. Jagan suspects that the master may have fathered the bearded man with a sex worker but keeps this thought to himself. He also wonders why the bearded man lets his beard grow so white if he makes hair dyes—but, rather than asking that, he asks after the bearded man's business. The man says it's fine, as he hasn't yet dealt with tax inspectors. Jagan recalls his own disturbing encounters with tax people and tax evasion; he thinks that he would have paid his sales taxes if Gandhi had told him to, but as far as he knows Gandhi didn't talk about that.

Just as Jagan eats an ascetic, sugar-free diet but runs a fried sweet shop, so the bearded man sells hair dyes but lets his own beard grow white. This parallel indicates that people engaged in commercial activity are sometimes ambivalent about the value of what they do or sell—suggesting that wealth and success in the commercial sphere may be less central to the good life than people's actions suggest they are.



The bearded man jokes that the tax people will notice his business once they "notice fewer gray hairs around." At this point, Jagan comments on the man's white beard. The bearded man says he has no desire to dye his beard and would never have worked in hair dye if he could have been an image-maker—but his master was supporting him financially, and after his master died, he walked into town and started his business. He feels his life was much better before.

The bearded man here states explicitly what was implicit in his earlier comments: he wants to be a religious image-maker but needs to make money to live. And so, he has settled for participating in a commercial activity, selling hair dyes, in which he has little interest and for which he has little respect. Commercial activity of questionable value is crowding out religion and spirituality from the characters' lives.



The bearded man walks into the sanctuary, points out an empty alcove to Jagan, and tells him that his master wanted to carve the goddess *Gayatri* for the space. In fact, his master had already chosen the stone for the statue. Abruptly, the bearded man goes looking for the chosen stone. Jagan, walking after him, feels as though he has traveled back in time, far away from his own business and Mali's ventures. As the bearded man searches, he points out to Jagan various empty pedestals and broken pieces that used to contain or be gods' images—and Jagan has a sudden, overwhelming feeling that his humdrum existence has been incredibly "narrow" and that he is approaching "a new *janma*."

Gayatri is the Hindu goddess of the Gayatri mantra, a famous and ceremonially important Hindu prayer. Jagan senses that the shrine is transporting him away from the modern era and humdrum commercial activity, which implies that devout religiosity conflicts with 20th century social mores and global capitalism. A "janma" is a birth, so when Jagan feels that he is approaching "a new janma," he means that he senses a spiritual rebirth approaching that will free him from his "narrow" existence.



The bearded man offers Jagan a piece of fruit from a nearby guava tree. Jagan takes it but tells the bearded man he doesn't eat sugar or salt. When the bearded man asks why, Jagan begins to talk about his book and the printer Nataraj, which doesn't at all interest the bearded man, as he is more "used to inscriptions on stone and on palmyra leaf." Jagan takes one bite of the guava and drops it, recalling how he ate fruit all the time as a child until his father chopped down the guava tree in their own back yard.

Though Jagan seems to consider his dietary restrictions vaguely spiritual, the bearded man's utter lack of interest in them suggests that Jagan's dietary restrictions may be a form of bogus spirituality rather than a genuinely religious practice. The bearded man's association with "inscriptions on stone and on palmyra leaf"—earlier forms of transmitting writing than paper books—represents his pre-modern commitments and his opposition to the commercialization of art and literature inherent in Mali's story-writing machines.



Wrapped up in these thoughts, Jagan loses track of the bearded man until the bearded man asks whether Jagan is paying attention. When Jagan claims he is, the man bewails that they haven't found the stone—and then remembers where it is. They go down to the pond—and as they do, Jagan suddenly worries that the bearded man will drown him in this remote spot and then tell the townspeople he vanished. Jagan is almost tempted by the idea of dying to avoid his problems. He wonders how he will be reincarnated and concludes, "Anything but a money-making sweet-maker with a spoilt son."

Jagan is so sick of conflict with his "spoilt son" Mali that he fantasizes about the bearded man murdering him—a fantasy implying that in some moods, Jagan would rather die than confront Mali directly and have a real, definitive argument with him. Meanwhile, Jagan's contemptuous reference to himself as a "money-making sweet-maker" shows his growing unease with his own commercial activity.



The bearded man orders Jagan to reach into the pool and feel around. Beneath the water, the bearded man grabs Jagan's hand, startling him, and places it on the stone—which, he explains, his master put in the pond for "water treatment." He bullies the rather weak-feeling Jagan into helping him lift the stone from the water and carry it up some steps to the grass. When Jagan has recovered from the exertion, the bearded man shows him the outline of the 10-armed goddess that his master had sketched on the stone. The bearded man begins telling Jagan a story about the goddess; when Jagan interrupts, saying he knows the story, the bearded man says that everyone does—but it's good to hear it repeated.

"Water treatment" of stone involves long, slow erosion; the centrality of water treatment to the creation of this religious image suggests that religion operates on a different, slower timescale than the frenetic commercial activity characteristic of the modern era. Meanwhile, the bearded man's claim that it's good to hear religious stories repeated poses an implicit opposition between religion and traditional art on the one hand, and Mali's story-writing machines on the other (as their purpose is to create many new and disposable commercial novels).



The bearded man says he'll die happy if he can spend the rest of his life carving this statue. When Jagan asks how old he is, the bearded man asks him to guess—but when Jagan, confused, demurs, the man announces that he's 69 and prepared to die at 70 if he can complete the statue and put it on the empty pedestal. He and Jagan discuss whether he'll be able to finish the statue in a year—and then he breaks into an excited description of the goddess and the objects she holds in her 10 hands, a description that leaves Jagan wonderstruck.

The bearded man wants to devote the short rest of his life to making a religious image, showing the centrality of religion to his value system. Implicitly, it is this devoutness that leaves Jagan wonderstruck when the bearded man explains to him in rapturous detail how he wants to design the statue of the goddess.



Suddenly, the bearded man tells Jagan that only Jagan can help him complete the goddess—by purchasing the property and installing the statue. When Jagan hesitates, the bearded man points at him threateningly and said that it seemed having “a retreat like this” would help Jagan. Jagan agrees that he would like a retreat and a drastic change. The bearded man expands on this idea, claiming that eventually, all old people must retreat from the world, ceding it to new generations. Jagan wants to say more about what he wants, but he is unwilling to explain the pain that Mali has caused him.

The bearded man, like Mali, has approached Jagan to ask him to invest—but whereas Mali wants Jagan to invest in commercial activity characteristic of the new generation, the bearded man wants Jagan to cede worldly, commercial affairs to the new generation and devote himself wholly to religion. Yet Jagan, at this point still a poor communicator, neither definitively agrees to the bearded man's proposal nor shares the feelings the proposal brings up.



CHAPTER 9

Jagan returns home and begins spinning yarn—a practice that Gandhi recommended both for economic reasons and for bringing psychological calm. He feels as though he has undergone a metamorphosis through divine intervention thanks to the bearded man—yet he wonders whether he should help the man on his mission and what he would do afterwards. Would they live in the remote shrine together? Would the bearded man expect Jagan to take over his hair dye business and “ruin Mali further” with wealth? Jagan tells himself that he is no longer a sweet-shop owner and Mali's father but wonders what, in that case, he is—a patron or follower of the bearded man?

The juxtaposition of Jagan's religious experience and his political commitments suggests that for Jagan, Hindu piety and Indian patriotism are closely related. Yet Jagan is worried that the bearded man may have ulterior motives. Specifically, he worries that the bearded man may want Jagan to run his business. Jagan fears that if he accrues any more wealth, it will “ruin Mali further”; this fear shows that Jagan believes his own business acumen poisoned Mali's character, making Mali too interested in money. In deciding that he is no longer Mali's father, however, Jagan chooses once again to avoid Mali rather than confront him and discuss their different values.



Mali enters and asks Jagan to stop spinning the wheel so they can talk. When Jagan nervously asks what Mali wants, Mali tells him that he's received a cable from his “associates.” The word “associates” no longer intimidates Jagan. Feeling gentle toward his son, he asks what the cable says. Mali says it asks about the business venture's “status” and demands to know whether Jagan plans to join it. Jagan, sorry about Mali's distress and about the “barrier” between them, offers to give Mali the sweet shop. Mali says he should be able to offer India the knowledge he learned in America—and anyway, the sweet shop has no value anymore, as all the food vendor people in town are gossiping.

The word “associates” used to frighten Jagan, which indicates that he avoided discussing business with Mali in part because he was intimidated by Mali's foreign partners. After his religious experience, Jagan no longer feels this fear, which shows how religion can buffer the devout against worldly cares. Since the cable was about the business venture's “status,” readers can infer that Mali has no backup plan: despite the contempt he shows Jagan, he needs Jagan to invest in his business or it cannot go forward. Mali's rationale for refusing the sweet-shop reveals that he thinks the business is too Indian and that he longs to Americanize India, in sharp contrast with Jagan's patriotism and anti-Western sentiments.



Mali launches into another pitch for his business. When Jagan asks what will happen if he says no to the business, Mali says Grace will return to America. Jagan asks why, and Mali says Grace has no occupation in India. Jagan, baffled, asks to talk to Grace directly. Mali says she's out. When Jagan asks where, Mali retorts that Grace is free to go where she likes, and Jagan—feeling that miscommunication is sadly inevitable between him and Mali—asks where Grace goes and whether she's "unhappy." Mali says again she is free, "not like the daughters-in-law in our miserable country."

Whereas Jagan assumes that Mali and Grace's marriage is separate from their business interests, Mali makes clear that his continued cohabitation with Grace depends on their ability to work together, an idea Jagan finds foreign. Unusually, Jagan attempts to ask Mali direct questions in this scene, but rather than respond directly, Mali criticizes Indian gender politics and calls India a "miserable country." Mali's evasiveness shows that while Jagan exacerbates the communication problems between him and his son, the problems aren't all Jagan's fault.



When Jagan asks again whether Grace is unhappy, Mali says that she has nothing to be happy about because she has no work. Jagan wants to say that she has housework, but he keeps quiet. Instead, he says that wives have to stay with their husbands. Mali says that was true in Jagan's generation and leaves. Jagan spends the rest of the night worrying about Grace.

Mali assumes that Grace's happiness depends on her participation in the commercial sphere—an interesting assumption given how often the novel questions whether commerce and capitalism contribute to a good, happy life. Mali also strongly implies here that Jagan's commitment to traditional marriage is characteristic of his older generation but not of Mali's younger one.



CHAPTER 10

Jagan wants to talk to Grace, but though he hears her moving about the house, she hasn't come into his section of the house for 10 days. He wonders whether she was only kind to him while she thought he might invest in the **story-writing machines**, and he feels as though an impenetrable wall has arisen between him on the one hand and Grace and Mali on the other.

Jagan's inaction here shows both how his fears prevent him from communicating effectively and how the story-writing machines symbolize failures of communication between Jagan and the younger generation.



At the sweets shop, when Jagan asks the cousin whether he has run into Mali lately, the cousin says he ran into Mali at an acquaintance's house. Mali told the cousin that Grace would be returning to America on a business trip. The cousin praises the gumption of modern women, traveling alone for business—and Jagan, keeping quiet about the real nature of Grace's trip, asks the cousin to distract Mali so that he can talk to Grace alone. The cousin goes along with the plan, though he's aware Jagan isn't telling him something.

Once again, Jagan uses the cousin as a go-between or buffer in his communications with Mali and Grace. This time, however, Jagan is at least planning to talk to Grace. His resolve to discuss problems with Grace directly shows how important he believes her marriage to Mali is and how undesirable her leaving would be.



Two days later, while Mali is showing the cousin the land where he plans to build the factory for his business, Jagan goes into the *puja* room and prays for guidance. Then he goes and knocks on Grace's door. While he waits, he remembers how decisive he used to be—for example, when as a young man he climbed the bungalow of the British Collector to replace the Union Jack with the Indian flag. He moved so fast the nearby police couldn't stop him—though afterwards they beat him unconscious and put him in jail. Jagan thinks that he still has his *Satyagrahi* training but that it's receded into the background of his personality somehow.

Grace opens her door, greets Jagan, and invites him in. After Jagan makes some introductory comments, he tells himself not to dither and “lose [his] daughter” Grace as he feels he's nearly lost Mali. He asks why he doesn't see her around the house anymore. When she blushes and stays silent, he tells her not to answer and asks instead whether she wants to return to America. A crow caws outside, and rather than answering Jagan, Grace goes to feed it. Jagan suddenly intuits that Grace is fragile and might break down if he interrogates her. Feeling afraid of her, he announces he must return to the shop.

Grace, walking Jagan out, says that “Mo”—Mali—wants her to return to America. Jagan, shocked, asks why. Grace explains that Mali says he can't pay for her to stay in India anymore; she has used up the \$2,000 she came with, and Mali has “no more use” for her. Jagan says that he cared for his wife whether or not he had “use” for her and that according to the *puranas*, wives and husbands should stay together.

Grace admits that she and Mali aren't married, though Mali promised to marry her according to Indian cultural traditions when he brought her. Jagan asks whether the marriage took place after they arrived, and Grace says Jagan would know if it had. Jagan exclaims in shock. Grace asks Jagan to stay and hear her explain—but Jagan, thinking Grace is sinful though seemingly virtuous, says he can't stay.

When Jagan prays for guidance before talking to Grace, it shows both how much he fears direct confrontation and how his religious devotion sometimes gives him strength and courage. “Satyagrahi” is a term that refers to political activists who practiced nonviolent resistance during the Indian independence movement. When Jagan contrasts his decisiveness as a Satyagrahi with his current vacillations and timidity, it suggests that his political activism gave him strength while his many years in business made him soft and indecisive.



Jagan refers to Grace as his “daughter,” which indicates that he feels familial responsibility and affection for her due to her relationship with Mali. Yet even though Jagan has resolved not to “lose” his “daughter” Grace, a few moments of silence from Grace strike terror into him and cause him to give up. Jagan's quick defeat here shows how seriously his interpersonal fearfulness damages his ability to communicate and foster relationships.



Grace's explanation strongly implies that Mali has been using Grace for her money to fund his commercial ventures: now that she has no more money and there is no business for her to work in, he has “no more use” for her. Jagan's response suggests that he finds the infiltration of commercial “use” into marriage repulsive. By mentioning the puranas, Hindu scriptures, he also suggests that Mali's commercial attitude toward marriage is irreligious.



Jagan's utter shock that Mali and Grace have been living together while unmarried suggests a major difference in sexual mores between Jagan's generation on the one hand and Mali and Grace's on the other. Yet again, Jagan flees rather than listening to Grace's explanations or even criticizing her, emphasizing his difficulties with frank communication.



When the cousin enters the shop, Jagan tells him that Mali isn't married. The cousin asks whether Jagan talked with Grace, and Jagan repeats that she and Mali aren't married. The cousin suggests that she should be allowed to return to America, then, and adds that the younger generation lives "in a different world"—so elders shouldn't be outraged by their behavior. Jagan retorts that even his infamously depraved great-uncle never lied about being married when he wasn't and—thinking about all the sin that may have occurred under his roof—says that his "home is tainted."

The cousin suggests that Jagan ask Mali's "side of the story." Jagan points out that Mali told him he wanted Grace to return to America. When the cousin claims that this is because Mali is occupied with his business, Jagan exclaims, "What business!" The cousin suggests that Grace and Mali's relationship is "their business" and that Jagan should take the Gita's teachings on detachment seriously. Jagan bemoans that he is always seeking detachment but never finds it.

Jagan asks the cousin how he can continue living in his house. The cousin suggests he use the back entrance to avoid Grace and Mali; Jagan agrees and asks the cousin not to tell anyone about the situation. The cousin swears. When Jagan asks what he should do about Grace and Mali, the cousin suggests he can get them a fast marriage. Jagan expresses effusive gratitude.

CHAPTER 11

Jagan spends an entire morning shutting off his part of the house from Mali and Grace's. After he leaves the house by the back door, he takes a side lane toward the main street and recalls how he and his older brother used to catch grasshoppers in this lane, while their sister threatened to snitch on their animal-harming behavior. Jagan believes that his siblings disliked him: his sister married a rich, rural moron while his brother stopped speaking to him after their father's death and the parceling out of the inheritance.

When the cousin says that Grace and Mali live "in a different world," he seems to mean that they have grown up in such a different cultural context than people of Jagan and the cousin's generation that the older generation cannot properly judge the younger's actions or morals. Jagan is unconvinced by the cousin's generational relativism, and his declaration that his "home is tainted" implies that he feels a spiritual disgust at cohabiting with an unmarried couple.



Due to the cousin's relativism about generational mores, he is willing to accept that Mali might have a legitimate "story" to tell about why he's trying to send Grace away. He even suggests that it's reasonable for Mali to neglect Grace if Mali is occupied with his business. Jagan's exclamation, "What business!", implies both that Jagan is contemptuous of Mali's story-writing machines and that he doesn't think business is a good reason to neglect or destroy interpersonal relationships. Meanwhile, Jagan and the cousin's conversation about learning detachment from the Gita suggests how difficult it is for even a devout man like Jagan to put religious beliefs into practice.



Though Grace and Mali have scandalized Jagan's morals, he and the cousin ultimately decide that Jagan should avoid them rather than confronting them—an unproductive tack characteristic of timid Jagan. Meanwhile, though the cousin has defended Grace and Mali's premarital cohabitation as natural for people of the younger generation, he quickly promises to help Jagan marry them off. This flip-flopping indicates that the cousin, a busybody, is more interested in being involved in the family drama than he is in defending particular principles.



Jagan follows through on avoiding Grace and Mali rather than confronting them—a decision that shows how his attempts to communicate directly with them have backslid since he learned of their unmarried status. Meanwhile, Jagan's reminiscences about his estrangement from his siblings hints that if he loses Grace and Mali, he will lose all the remaining family with whom he has a relationship.



Now all Jagan's relatives are shunning him because of Grace: his sister sent him a nasty postcard about having a "beef-eating Christian girl for a daughter-in-law" while his brother has reportedly been speaking ill of Jagan, blaming him for how Mali has turned out. In truth, Jagan is happy to be the black sheep of the family—it allows him to avoid family obligations.

While the cousin may tolerate the different moral values of the younger generation, others of Jagan's older generation clearly do not. When Jagan's sister calls Grace a "beef-eating Christian girl," she is expressing intense displeasure that Mali has entered an interreligious relationship, and Jagan's brother seems to have a similarly negative reaction to Mali's secularism. Interestingly, Jagan doesn't mind his sibling's disapproval because it helps him dodge family responsibilities; this attitude suggests that he is at least partially to blame for the siblings' estrangement.



As Jagan walks to the sweets shop, Mali and Grace drive up in the **green car** and stop. Grace asks whether Jagan wants a ride. Jagan refuses. Grace asks whether he was "spring-cleaning" earlier, and Jagan says meaningfully that he was trying to "clean [his] surroundings." Mali stays silent; noting his tired appearance, Jagan wishes he could solve their conflict by writing a check for the **story-writing machine** business—but then he thinks that even if he did, Grace and Mali would still be unmarried and driving around together.

Earlier in the novel, Mali's purchase of the green car represented his materialism and desire for a commercial status symbol. Given that Mali and Grace are riding around in the car together while estranged, the car now seems to symbolize how Mali and Grace's shared materialism won't keep them together or make them happy. Jagan is deeply upset with Grace and Mali for their unmarried cohabitation in his house, but rather than tell them so directly, he makes a snide comment about needing to "clean [his] surroundings"—implicitly, of their sexual impurity—that shows how inept he remains at frank, open communication.



Two weeks later, Jagan realizes he hasn't seen or heard Grace in a while. One day, Mali hears Jagan sneaking by, calls to him, and asks why he's "prowling around like this." They meet in the garden, and Jagan says he'd like to talk to both Mali and Grace. Mali brusquely explains that Grace is staying with friends and asks why Jagan has locked the door between the two sides of the house. Before Jagan replies, Mali announces that locking the door won't prevent Mali from pursuing his venture—and he wants to know what Jagan will do.

It takes another two weeks of silence for Mali and Jagan to talk to each other again, even though Jagan has been "prowling around," avoiding Mali in a way that Mali couldn't help but notice. Though Mali does ask why Jagan has locked the door between the two sides of the house, he doesn't wait for Jagan's response; instead, he demands an answer about his business venture. Mali's refusal to wait for Jagan's response shows his single-minded focus on his business idea and underscores that Mali as well as Jagan is at fault for their poor communication.



Jagan announces that Mali and Grace need to get married. When Mali shouts that Jagan has been talking behind his back, Jagan says that he has arranged for a fast wedding. Mali says that Grace has developed "funny notions," which is why he told Jagan to "pack her off"—but Jagan was too cheap to pay for her travel. He claims that Grace needs to see a psychiatrist. When Jagan asks what a psychiatrist is, Mali expresses contempt at his ignorance, calls the town a "back wood," and leaves. A neighbor greets Jagan at the garden fence, and Jagan flees before the neighbor can ask him about his "daughter-in-law." He's not sure whether Grace or Mali told him the truth.

In this scene, Mali says that he told Jagan to send Grace away, shifting responsibility for Grace onto Jagan even though Mali brought her to India in the first place. By claiming that Jagan was too cheap to pay for Grace's travel back to the U.S., meanwhile, Mali falsely implies that he and Jagan are having another commercial dispute rather than a serious generational conflict over moral values. The contemptuous phrase "pack her off" suggests Mali's lack of respect or affection for Grace.



CHAPTER 12

Jagan, anxious and preoccupied, goes through his workday in a daze. While he counts his cash, he internally compares his inability to understand Mali to the warrior Arjuna's inability to comprehend the entirety of God in the *Bhagavad Gita*—though he knows the comparison is rather sacrilegious.

That evening, sitting on a colonial statue pedestal near his house, Jagan recalls traveling to a village called Kuppam to meet a possible bride suggested to him by older family members. In a flashback, Jagan's older brother comes along as a chaperone on the trip. When they arrive at the possible bride's house, her family greets him in an outer area of the house and asks Jagan polite questions about his journey while Jagan tries to cultivate the quiet mystique appropriate to a bridegroom. The whole time, Jagan looks around trying to get a glimpse of the possible bride, of whom he has only seen a poor-quality photograph.

When the possible bride's family serves food, Jagan wants to eat it all—he hasn't yet given up salt and sugar—but his brother gives him a stern look, so Jagan eats little, pretending that he is only eating out of courtesy to his hosts. Afterward, his possible mother-in-law invites the party into the house proper. Jagan knows he shouldn't act too eager to see his possible bride—he has ruined four previous visits to possible brides by staring at the girls, hence his older brother's presence as a chaperone on this trip. Yet he feels impatient.

The party sits in the home's central hall. Jagan hears a harmonium playing and a rather deep woman's voice—Ambika's—singing inside. Then, after several people urge the shy Ambika to emerge, she does—only for Jagan, vision "clouded with a happy haze," to miss most details of her appearance. Yet she shoots him a "lightning glance" that makes his heart race. Then, abruptly, the visit ends.

As Jagan and his brother begin their journey home, Jagan is thoughtful and silent. At the rail station, Jagan admits he likes Ambika, and his brother says he hopes Jagan hasn't been "a fool" and hasn't "cheapened" himself by saying as much to her relatives. Jagan assures his brother that he hasn't—though he was longing to exchange another look of love with Ambika before he left.

*While Jagan may feel that comparing his relationship with Mali to Arjuna's relationship with God in the *Bhagavad Gita* is blasphemous, the spontaneous comparison nevertheless shows how Hinduism helps Jagan interpret important aspects of his life, in this case his repeated failures to communicate with or understand his son.*



By explaining how Jagan got married, the novel is implicitly contrasting the romantic and sexual mores of Jagan's generation with those of Mali and Grace's generation. Jagan's older family members selected a possible bride for him, and Jagan's older brother accompanied him to meet her—in stark contrast with how Mali met Grace, by chance and unchaperoned in the U.S.



Mali resents whenever Jagan tries to get involved in his life—perhaps especially when Jagan tries to get involved in his dispute with Grace. By contrast, Jagan is excited and impatient to meet the possible bride that his older family members have selected for him. This contrast shows the difference in cultural attitudes between Mali's generation and Jagan's.



The "happy haze" that Jagan experiences in Ambika's presence and the "lightning glance" she sends him suggests that they become infatuated with each other at first sight. This immediate infatuation implies that quasi-arranged marriages aren't necessarily less romantic than spontaneous romances of Mali's generation—and indeed may be more romantic, given Mali's commercial and exploitative attitude toward Grace.



Jagan's brother believes that Jagan would have "cheapened" himself and acted like "a fool" by admitting to Ambika's relatives that he liked her. This belief shows how sexually modest the mores of Jagan's generation were, in sharp contrast to Mali's.



Jagan and his brother get back to Malgudi early the next morning. Soon the whole family is involved in cementing plans for Jagan and Ambika's wedding. Jagan's father writes to various older relatives to get their consent; after getting their consent, he consults with Jagan's mother. Jagan—who as the involved party isn't supposed to show interest—hears tidbits about how things are proceeding from his sister. When she tells him that Ambika's family wants the wedding in September, Jagan is shocked and nervous to think that he could be a husband in three months.

Finally, Jagan's father sends a letter approving the marriage to Ambika's family. A multitude of letters pass between the families—and then, one night, Ambika's family arrives, as do priests, relatives, and neighbors. An elderly priest reads a painstakingly prepared wedding notice stating that "Jagannath" will marry Ambika on September 10th. Ambika's father gives Jagan's father a dowry of \$2,500 rupees and politely insists that Jagan's older brother counts it to make sure the sum is correct. Then the whole assembly has an enormous meal together. Jagan is shocked that so many people are celebrating.

September approaches. Jagan's father tells him to take time off college to help with the preparations. Jagan is fitted for a tweed suit, though he'd rather wear a *dhoti* and *jibba*, while his mother goes to buy saris for Ambika and other members of the wedding party at Universal Saree Emporium. Meanwhile, Jagan's father tries to make sure that everyone "remotely connected" with Jagan is invited, not forgotten.

Ultimately, 3,000 people are invited to Jagan and Ambika's wedding, which takes place in Kuppam. Jagan feels that he spends the whole celebration greeting various people, though in fact he and Ambika also go through a series of sacred rituals, and the "sacred *thali*" that Ambika is wearing makes him feel a tremendous sense of duty. He longs to be alone with her, but people keep dragging him back to his guests when he tries to snatch a moment with her.

The involvement of Jagan's whole family with his marriage sharply contrasts with Mali's behavior with Grace: he introduced Grace to his father while claiming already to have married her, completely cutting Jagan out of his courtship process. This difference shows how badly communication has broken down between Mali and Jagan as well as exemplifying the different marriage customs of Jagan's generation and Mali's.



The presence of priests at the wedding announcement emphasizes that Jagan and Ambika's wedding is a religious affair as well as a social one. The religiosity of Jagan's marriage implicitly contrasts with the secularism of the younger generation that Mali represents. Meanwhile, the scene involving the dowry shows that commerce and money concerns already impinged upon Jagan's family's interpersonal relationships before money-obsessed Mali was even born—though Mali's Americanized obsession with capitalist wealth accumulation is framed as being on an entirely different level.



Jagan's preference for traditional Indian garments over a British-style tweed suit shows his nascent anti-U.K. sentiment, while the decision that he wear a tweed suit for his traditional Hindu wedding shows the impact of British culture on India due to the UK's colonial rule. Meanwhile, Jagan's father's insistence that everyone "remotely connected" to Jagan come to his wedding shows the importance of social ties to earlier generations, in contrast with the relative social isolation of Mali's generation.



In Tamil Hindu weddings, a thali is a religiously significant gold wedding necklace that the groom gives to the bride. The reference to Ambika's thali in this passage emphasizes that Jagan feels a religious and social as well as a personal responsibility to be a good husband to Ambika. Jagan's feelings of responsibility to Ambika implicitly contrast with Mali's cavalier attitude toward Grace and with his more secular, freewheeling attitudes toward romantic partnership and sex.



There are two unfortunate incidents during the wedding. First, a highly respected 75-year-old relative of Jagan's is accidentally seated with the children—but Ambika's father apologizes and is forgiven. Second, the "gold waist-belt" in the list of jewelry that Ambika's family was supposed to leave with their daughter turns out not to be solid gold but a mix of gold bars and silk cords. When Jagan tries to defend Ambika, he is called "hen-pecked" and "obsessed."

Notably, the two unfortunate incidents at the wedding have nothing to do with Jagan and Ambika's relationship. Instead, the incidents have to do with their families. That these incidents nevertheless seem highly important to the wedding's outcome shows how embedded in a larger familial and social context Jagan and Ambika's relationship is—in implicit contrast with Grace and Mali's, where Jagan is the only older relative with whom the young pair seem to have a relationship. Meanwhile, when Jagan's relatives ridicule him for being "hen-pecked" and "obsessed" with Ambika, it implies that Jagan is deeply infatuated with her and thus that romance can spring from quasi-arranged marriages.



After the marriage, Jagan and Ambika get a room in the middle of the family house. Jagan spends all the time he can having sex with her, neglecting his classes and failing his exams, until Jagan's father suggests they send Ambika back to her family for several months while Jagan gets his degree. Ambika, meanwhile, points out that she has household duties and can't spend all her time with Jagan. Various family members comment on how Jagan is only interested in spending time with her, not anyone else.

Jagan's family comments disapprovingly on how wrapped up he is in Ambika, and Ambika herself is annoyed at him for distracting her from her household duties. These details shows that for Jagan's generation, a marriage was part of a larger web of familial relationships rather than an isolated bond between just two people.



Yet after almost 10 years of marriage, Jagan and Ambika still have not had a child—and meanwhile, Jagan has failed to get his B.A. Jagan's older brother moves with his family to their own house, while Jagan's sister gets married and moves to her husband's house. Jagan's mother begins to complain that the house is empty, and that Ambika is not providing grandchildren. Alone in their room, Jagan jokingly suggests that Ambika should pretend that she has stopped getting her period—but of course, he's joking, as menstruating women have to self-isolate in an "orthodox household with all the *pujas* and the Gods."

In some versions of Hinduism, menstruating women are supposed to avoid religiously significant places and items. Ambika would have to avoid the house's puja room while menstruating, which would make clear to everyone in the household when she had her period. This fact shows both the enmeshment of Jagan and Ambika's marriage in a larger familial context and the importance of religion in their lives—again in stark context with the secular, socially atomized younger generation Mali represents.



Ambika argues that the infertility doesn't come from her family, as all her sisters have had children. Jagan, stung, argues that his family is very prolific too. The couple, frustrated, starts having less sex, and Jagan takes to sleeping out on the veranda. Yet Ambika herself very much wants a child and begins mocking Jagan for sleeping outside.

When Ambika and Jagan begin fighting over their infertility, Jagan starts sleeping out on the veranda rather than with Ambika—showing that his avoidant, passive-aggressive behavior long predates his communication problems with Mali.



One morning, Jagan's father abruptly announces that Jagan and Ambika will be traveling to a temple on Badri Hill with him the following week. He tells Jagan to take several days off college. When Jagan asks why, his father says the temple cures barren women. Jagan wants to defend Ambika but feels unable to talk about her family's fertility to his father. He has recently started trying to study harder to at least keep his family from blaming her for his educational failures. Yet when Jagan asks his father whether they can postpone the Badri Hill trip until after his exams, his father refuses, saying they have to make the trip before the rains come and prevent it.

On the appointed day, Ambika, Jagan, and Jagan's parents take a bus to the base of Badri Hill. Jagan has to sit with his father, who looks like "someone going out to negotiate a contract," while Ambika has to sit with Jagan's mother. The bus is overfull and very loud; Jagan, seeing that the chaotic atmosphere is wearing Ambika down, wishes that he could sit with her and tease her—though even after years of marriage, he can't anticipate whether she would tease back good-humoredly or snap at him. A couple weeks ago, when Jagan's mother criticized Ambika for oversalting a sauce, Ambika snapped, hid in her room, and refused to eat. Since then, Jagan's mother has refrained from criticizing Ambika too much.

When Ambika, Jagan, and Jagan's parents disembark from the bus, Jagan's father goes to buy food from a coconut-seller and complains about the inflated tourist prices. Jagan wishes he could tell his parents that they have sufficient grandchildren and so can leave him alone, but he doesn't. The coconut-seller tells Jagan's father not to whine about the price—he'll be compensated with a grandson soon. And sure enough, Mali is born, after which the family delivers offerings to Badri Hill to fulfill the oath they made.

Ambika goes with Mali to visit her own parents, who give her many gifts and hold a feast in honor of her first-born child. Her father and Jagan's father agree to start a savings account for Mali, and Ambika and Jagan feel proud and happy to be parents.

Jagan's father can order Jagan to take a pilgrimage and miss school—another stark contrast with Jagan and Mali's relationship, where Mali is the one who bullies (or tries to bully) his father. Readers see another example of Jagan's early avoidant behaviors when—rather than defend Ambika directly from his family's accusations—he tries to study harder so they at least won't blame her for his failure at various college exams.



The novel usually portrays religion and commerce as opposed activities. Yet Jagan's father's expression of "going out to negotiate a contract" suggests that he sees prayer as a kind of commercial trade: you give prayer to a deity, and in exchange they give you what you want—in this case, a baby for Jagan and Ambika. Thus the novel complicates its representation of religion and commerce as opposites by showing that some people take a fundamentally commercial attitude toward religion while still practicing it.



Yet again, Jagan fails to tell the people around him what he's really thinking, agreeing to his parents' desires rather than announcing that he doesn't want to go on the pilgrimage. Meanwhile, the coconut seller's language of trade and compensation in reference to the pilgrimage emphasizes that some people have a fundamentally commercial and transactional attitude toward their god or gods.



Readers know that Jagan and Mali's relationship will deteriorate dramatically after Ambika's death both due to failures in communication and unavoidable generational differences. As such, Ambika and Jagan's joy at parenthood in this scene is sadly ironic.



CHAPTER 13

Back in the present, Jagan has fallen asleep while thinking about the past. Birds wake him where he has been sleeping by the statue. He looks at his house and thinks that Mali and Grace have failed to brighten it the way his own mother and Ambika did during happier times. He consoles himself with the thought that he is already 60 and won't have to live much longer in the house. Then, imagining Mali living in the house all his life, he wonders where Grace will be when Mali is 80—still in the same situation? Jagan concludes that Grace should return to America unless Mali agrees to marry her quickly.

Recalling how Mali rejected the idea of a quick marriage, Jagan concludes that he no longer has a place in his family home and decides: "At sixty, one is reborn." He recalls how people used to ritually celebrate their 60th birthdays—and then decides to take a page from Mali's book and eschew rituals, "bonds," "links," and "responsibility." He recalls how Grace and Mali sat together with their legs touching in the **green car** and feels an exhausted confusion—but he decides not to try to figure it out anymore.

Jagan enters the house and packs a few things, including his *charka* so that he can continue spinning as he vowed he would in front of Gandhi. Then he tries to figure out where to leave the back-door key. He considers leaving it with his older brother, recalling how his family saw him off when he went to jail for the National Struggle even though they disapproved of the movement. Jagan wonders whether his brother would see him off on his new journey now. But then he thinks that his brother will have heard the rumors about Grace and Mali and scorn Jagan as a result—so Jagan decides he'll keep the key.

As Jagan walks away from the house, the cousin speeds by on a bicycle and then falls off. When Jagan exclaims, the cousin gets up and explains that he borrowed the bicycle because he was rushing to see Jagan. Jagan announces that he is leaving home forever. The cousin, struck by his brusqueness, says that Mali needs immediate help: the police found him with alcohol in his **car** and have put him in prison. Jagan shouts that he warned Mali against purchasing "that horrible car," which must have given him ideas.

Jagan has religious and generationally characteristic objections to Mali and Grace's cohabitation. To fix what he views as their inappropriate relationship, he wants them to get married. Yet he is willing to accept Grace's return to the U.S. if it will protect her from Mali's long-term refusal to commit, which suggests that he has come to care for Grace's wellbeing even though he now knows she isn't his daughter-in-law.



Previously, Jagan tied the concept of rebirth to his experience in the bearded man's shrine, which suggests that he wants to be "reborn" in a religious or spiritual sense. Yet his previous religious practices have been tied up with social and familial "bonds" and "responsibility," e.g. the intense responsibility he felt for Ambika during their traditional Hindu wedding. As such, his rejection of "bonds," "links," and "responsibility" in this scene hints that his supposed religious rebirth is just another way to avoid communicating with and trying to understand Mali. The confusion Jagan feels at the memory of Mali and Grace in the green car, a commercial status symbol, emphasizes that Jagan does not understand the younger generation's commercial or sexual culture.



A charka is a spinning wheel. Jagan's decision to continue his daily spinning during his religious hermitage out of respect for Gandhi emphasizes again how intertwined his Hinduism and his Indian patriotism are. Meanwhile, Jagan's alienation from his older brother emphasizes how utterly alone he is as a result of the breakdown of communication between him and Mali.



At first glance, Jagan's claim that Mali's "horrible car" is what led him astray seems humorously backwards. Yet insofar as the car represents Mali's Americanized materialism and commercial aspirations, Jagan may be right. Alcohol was illegal in Tamil Nadu, the region of India where the novel is implied to take place, until 1971. Due to Mali's Westernized contempt for Indian social norms and his materialistic confusion about what will make him happy, he has flouted local law to drink—with legal repercussions.



The cousin says that Mali is in jail and that they could have bailed him out the previous night, if only the cousin had been able to find Jagan. Jagan explains he was sleeping outside. He moans that he knows how awful the jail is—but he and the cousin conclude it must be better now than it was in the colonial period. The cousin goes on to explain that Mali was in the **green car** with two friends when the police stopped them, searched the car, and charged them under the Prohibition Act with possessing alcohol.

When Jagan admits that he didn't know Mali drank, the cousin says under Prohibition they can charge you even if you just smell like alcohol—but that a doctor can swear he gave Mali medicine with “an alcoholic flavour” before Mali was caught. When Jagan asks which doctor will do this, the cousin tells him the lawyer will handle it. Jagan asks where Mali was going in the **green car**, and the cousin says he was meeting with “foreign collaborators” and that a hitchhiker brought the alcohol into the car and left it there. Jagan is reassured by the possibility that this could be the case.

The cousin goes over possibilities for Mali's defense: the lawyer—who is thinking of buying stock in Mali's **story-writing machine** company—is investigating the possibility that the arresting officer might have a grudge against Jagan or Mali for some reason. Jagan says that if Mali's defense is true, then he'll be acquitted—but either way there is nothing Jagan can do. When the cousin protests that they must help Mali, who could be sentenced to two years, Jagan again says that the truth will decide. The cousin points out that the lawyer will have to establish the truth with “proper evidence.”

Jagan—feeling that he has come to an epiphany—wishes luck to everyone involved in the case but says he won't be involved: he is going away with nothing but the bag he's carrying. When the cousin asks where, Jagan tells him about the retreat. Horrified, the cousin asks whether the bearded man who sells hair dye has been trying to pawn off the place on Jagan—and warns Jagan off the bearded man, whom he describes as dangerous.

Jagan and the cousin's agreement that the jail must be better after India's 1947 independence than it was under the UK's colonial rule emphasizes their Indian patriotism. It also contrasts with Mali's contempt for Indian law and his Western materialism, as represented by his green car.



Mali was meeting with “foreign collaborators,” presumably Americans, when the police caught him with alcohol in his car. This emphasizes the symbolic connection between the green car and American capitalism's empty promises of happiness, which ultimately leave people worse off than they were before. (The cousin's story about the hitchhiker seems overwhelmingly unlikely to be true.)



Mali's lawyer plans to buy stock in the story-writing machine company, which symbolically associates him with commerce over art and with the ultimate breakdown of communication between Jagan and Mali. As such, it is unsurprising that Jagan refuses to cooperate with the lawyer in establishing “proper evidence,” insisting instead that if the lawyer is telling the truth, Mali will be fine.



It is unclear from Jagan's under-described epiphany whether he is having a genuine religious rebirth or whether he is simply using religious piety as an excuse to avoid further conflict and difficulty with Mali—as he has been avoiding difficult conversations with Mali the whole book. Either a sincere or an ironic reading of Jagan's actions seem possible.



Jagan insists that he plans to see a goddess carved from stone—and then stay or go as he sees fit. He encourages the cousin to think of him as a dead man from now on, gives him the keys to the shop for Mali to inherit eventually, and says that the cousin can always visit him at the retreat if he has questions. He gives the cousin a check for Mali's bail. Finally, he asks where Grace is. The cousin begins to explain that Grace's friends have found her a job in a hostel, but Jagan interrupts to say that he'll buy her a plane ticket if she wants—it's his responsibility, as she was "a good girl."

Jagan may be using his religious retreat partly to avoid difficult conversations and interactions with Mali, as he has been avoiding such conversations and interactions for the entire novel. Yet he is not only avoiding Mali: he has also decided to give up his business. Given the conflict that the novel poses between commerce and religion, Jagan's final choice suggests that he is definitively siding with religion over commerce as the path to a good life. Finally, Jagan's conclusion that Grace is a "good girl" suggests that he has come to believe her over Mali: she really did want to marry Mali and assimilate into the family, and Mali turned against her partly because he was interested in Americanizing India rather than having an American partner assimilate to Indian culture.





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